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P.P reshuffle may set course for cabinet rejig

Ram Madhav, Smriti Irani back in national organisational posts, younger faces added ahead of key elections

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday announced its much-anticipated new organisational team, bringing a few key leaders back into the party, promoting a bouquet of women leaders and inducting a number of young people with an eye on upcoming assembly elections, especially in Uttar Pradesh. The changes also point to those that might follow in a cabinet reshuffle that has been spoke of for months.

Seven months after appointing Nitin Nabin as the 12th national president of the BJP, the party announced 13 vice-presidents, six of them women. It dropped a clutch of key names and introduced new faces, including former national general secretary Ram Madhav and former Uttarakhand chief minister Tirath Singh Rawat.

Joining the team

Out of 13 national V-Ps, four were retained in the post. Of eight general secretaries, two were retained.

12 Women among 65 office-bearers

New national vice-presidents

Tirath Singh Rawat
Ram Madhav
D Purandeswari
Varshaben Narendrabhai Doshi
Bharti Pravin Pawar
Manpreet Singh Badal
Lal Singh Arya
M Nagaraja
Madhuchandra Kar

New national general secys

Biplab Kumar Deb
Smriti Irani
Safish Poonia
Gajendra Patel
Harish Dwivedi
Sanjay Bhatia
National treasurer
Piyush Goyal

"I am confident that every member, with the spirit of a dedicated karayakarta, will further strengthen the organisation to take forward the resolve of a Viksit Bharat and the commitment to nation-building to new heights."
— NITIN NABIN, BJP chief

BJP REPLACES AMIT MALVIYA, NAMES NEW SOCIAL MEDIA HEAD

The BJP on Monday replaced Amit Malviya as head of its social media department with Deepak Malviya, a former member of the board of Engineers India Limited. Malviya led the party's social media outreach for 11 years. Mhaskey, born in 1968, is the chairman of the Chhattisgarh Medical Services Corporation Limited (CMSCL). The party as part of its organisational reshuffle also named Priti Gandhi, Shivnandan Dwivedi, Alok Bhatt and Arun Yadav as social media co-convenors.

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NTA ORDERED TO AUDIT ALL EXAM PROCESSES, GIVE CENTRE REPORT

Sanjay Maurya
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NEW DELHI: The Union education ministry on Monday directed the National Testing Agency (NTA) to conduct a "thorough audit" of all examination processes and submit a "report on corrective action" within 30 days, officials said. A day after the body announced a re-examination for the UGC-NET in English commerce and sociology after a panel flagged errors in the question papers. A ministry spokesperson said the panel's findings were "internal", adding that NTA began "verification" immediately on receiving the complaints after examinations were completed on June 30.

BLACK MONEY IN POLLS: SC SETS 1-YR PROBE DEADLINE, ORDERS SPL COURTS

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday cracked down on the use of black money and other inducements in elections, directing completion of probes into electoral offences within a year. It also ordered to designate special courts for their speedy disposal and making their approval mandatory before prosecution against candidates in withdrawal of candidature in a particular election cycle.

UNEMPLOYMENT RATE IN 15-29 AGE GROUP RISES MARGINALLY IN JULY

Abhishek Jha
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NEW DELHI: India's headline unemployment rate fell to 5.1% in July from 5.2% a year ago, although unemployment of people in the 15-29 age group rose by 0.70 percentage points, a number that is bound to cause concern, especially in the wake of Gen Z protests across India last month. The numbers are from Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) data released by the National Statistics Office (NSO) on Monday.

Tughlakabad may face most cuts in Delhi SIR

Saloni Bhatia
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NEW DELHI: Roughly one in three voters in Delhi faces the risk of deletion from the electoral list after the first phase of the special intensive revision closed on Monday with official data showing that the assembly constituency of Rohini was set to face the heaviest and Tughlakabad the worst.

When the first phase of SIR—where people were given pre-filled forms by election officials to draw a link to the 2002 base roll—began on June 30, Delhi had a total of 14,50,299 electors.

Data shared by Delhi's chief electoral officer told 8pm showed that around 4.76 million voters, or 32.82%, face the risk of deletion when the draft rolls are published on August 24.

This means that the forms of these 4.76 million people have not yet been digitised when the deadline for the first phase

Likely cuts across segments

33% The deletions in Delhi at draft stage are not very different from deletions in other metros where SIR has been completed. Overall, a set in record around 37% cuts, according to data from the Karnataka CEO of August 16.



lapped on Monday. Electors identified as absent or shifted will have to file applications during the claims and objections period to have their names included in the final electoral roll, scheduled to be published on October 27. Telangana published its draft voter list on Monday while the first phase

of SIR also closed in Karnataka and Maharashtra.

"The deadline is till midnight. Some forms are still in the phase of digitisation. The final figures will be known on Tuesday," said an election official aware of the matter.

To be sure, the 32.8% deletion

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WB hotel fire kills 9 as locked exits trap guests

HT Correspondent
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KOLKATA: Nine people, including two children, were killed in a fire at a hotel at Tarapith, a temple town in West Bengal's Birbhum district, early on Monday, officials said, adding that a person was detained for alleged lapses in the maintenance of the fire-fighting system at the establishment.

The fire broke out around 4 am at the reception area on the ground floor of the four-storey hotel. Officials said the exact cause of the blaze is yet to be ascertained. However, hotel officials claimed while talking to reporters that the fire was caused by a short circuit near the hotel's reception after an electrical component of the power supply system caught fire.

Preliminary investigations



Forensic team visits the site of fire in Tarapith in Birbhum district on Monday.

revealed that the hotel's front door access was cut due to the fire in the reception area. Emergency exits on each floor were locked and the terrace door was also blocked with plywood, trapping the smoke, SP Vidit Raj Bhundesh said.

7 die as rumour sparks stampede near temple

Avinash Kumar
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PATNA: At least seven people were killed and 23 injured after an electric pole fell, triggering panic and confusion among a large crowd of devotees near the Ashok Dham temple in Bihar's Lakhisarai district on Monday, officials said.

Thousands of people had gathered to offer water to Lord Shiva when the electric pole fell on the path leading to the temple. "A rumour reportedly spread that the fallen pole was electrically charged, causing people to rush in different directions. The resulting panic led to a stampede, with several devotees falling and being crushed by the

crowd." Lakhisarai district magistrate Shaileendra Kumar said. Officials aware of the matter said the pole consisted of insulated cables and did not discharge live current after it fell. Three of the seven women who died were from the same family. The district administration set up a three-member inquiry team to probe the incident.

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TOP COURT PULLS UP ED AND CBI IN RAHUL ASSETS CASE

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday restrained CBI and ED from submitting any further evidence in the investigation of the Alakhnagar High Court in the Rahul Gandhi disproportionate assets case as it pulled up the agencies over their failure to act on their own if they had substantial material against the Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition.

Through the thrilling 73-minute contest,

AYUSH SHETTY TAKES DOWN WORLD NO.1 SHI AT BWF WORLDS
NEW DELHI: Rising Indian badminton star Ayush Shetty beat the defending champion and World Number 1 Shi Yu Qi at the BWF World Championships in New Delhi on Monday.

DGCA weighs wider drug testing; 2 more AI pilots under lens

Neha LM Tripathi
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NEW DELHI: Aviation safety regulator the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) may soon ask all domestic airlines to conduct drug tests for their pilots, a move prompted by the pilot of Air India's August 4 flight testing positive for drugs, and two other Air India pilots over the weekend, failing an initial drug test.

"DGCA is in the process of issuing an order on drug testing that will apply across all domestic airlines, rather than being limited to Air India." The order will be out soon, "a government official said, asking not to be named. Air India started drug tests for all its pilots from August 13, following the Phuket flight, which lost altitude suddenly, reportedly on account of technical issues, injuring several passengers and crew. It later emerged that the pilot had failed a preliminary drug test; subsequently, a confirmatory test returned a positive

result (for drug usage). Air India officials said that till Monday, around 400 pilots were tested, of which two failed a preliminary test. Results of their confirmatory tests were awaited as of this writing. Following the Phuket incident, the safety regulator asked DGCA to crack down on the problem and also work on its culture and ethics. Since then, DGCA has also been mulling amendments to the rules governing drug testing of aviation personnel, including stricter action against pilots who test positive for psychoactive substances.

"DGCA will also review the

VIJAY UNVEILS FULL WAIVER OF CROP LOANS UP TO ₹75K

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Vijay Varadachari on Monday announced a full waiver of crop loans in excess of up to ₹75,000 available by farmers. The waiver would cost the state exchequer ₹953 crore, he said in the assembly.

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Twisha case: Ex-judge, her son named for abatement of suicide

Shruti Tomar
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BHOPAL: Former actor-model in a shaggy night by suicide in May this year after facing sustained mental torture by her husband Samarth Singh and mother-in-law Birbala Singh, a former district judge, police started a charge sheet filed by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

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Twisha, 33, was found dead under suspicious circumstances at her marital home in Bhopal on May 12, just five months after she had filed a divorce case against her husband. A law firm that she was barred from practising by CBI on May 22. In the FIR, it was alleged that Samarth had taken her to AIMS Bhopal, where he claimed that she hanged herself at home at 10.20 pm. The doctors at AIMS informed the police that she was brought in dead to the hospital. In its nearly 600-page charge sheet filed before a special court in Bhopal on August 14, CBI has accused Samarth and Birbala Singh of "sustained psychological harm" on Twisha and charged them with abatement to deal with the protesters and said the constable who fired shots was suspended for his "undesired conduct".

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HC RAPS MAHA FDA FOR NOT RESTORING PUNE SHOP LICENCE

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MUMBAI: The Bombay HC on Monday told the Maharashtra FDA to pay a Pune sweet shop ₹5 lakh for keeping its license suspended, despite a 98% compliance during reinspection. It said continued suspension amounted to "torture and harassment".

continued on -11

U.S. NOT LOOKING TO EXTEND DEAL WITH IRAN: TRUMP

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said on Monday that the United States is not seeking an extension of the memorandum of understanding with Iran and that Tehran would not make the type of deal with Washington that he thought was necessary. Earlier, he threatened to bomb Oman if it "gets in the way" of a US deal with Tehran on the Strait of Hormuz.

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85% OF LPA: SKYMET SHARPLY REDUCES MONSOON FORECAST

Jasveer Gandhokh and Pallavi Singhal
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NEW DELHI: Private weather forecaster SkyMet Weather on Monday issued a revised forecast for the southwest monsoon, stating it now expects monsoon rainfall to be 85% of the long term average (LPA), with a 20% probability of drought.



Heroin, concealed in plastic soap cases, seized by authorities.

WORLD | SECURITY BREACH

UK's Burnham texted Trump aide imposter



British Prime Minister Andy Burnham exchanged messages with an imposter posing as U.S. President Donald Trump's chief of staff, according to reports published Monday. A spokesperson for Burnham declined to comment, saying it was policy not to discuss 'national security matters'. Politico cited four unnamed officials in first reporting that Burnham thought he was messaging with Susie Wiles before he became suspicious and cut off communications. The White House said the incident had nothing to do with Wiles' devices being hacked last year, the U.S. government investigated a series of messages that elected officials, business executives and other prominent figures in the U.S. received messages from someone posing as Wiles. The FBI had warned of 'malicious actors' missing AI to impersonate senior U.S. government officials. —APB

BUSINESS | FOR RERA RELIEF

SC to hear NBCC plea for Supertech projects



The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine the plea filed by government's construction arm NBCC India Limited seeking exemptions under the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act (RERA) for completion of the insolvent-ridden Supertech projects. A bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant issued notice on NBCC's plea challenging the May 22 order of the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) refusing to grant such an exemption. The tribunal had also turned down the plea for enhanced fees on sale of the unfinished flats in 16 Supertech projects taken over by NBCC in December 2024. The 16 Supertech projects are located in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Bengaluru. —APB

MY INDIA | SEEKS STATUS NEXT WEEK

SC asks K'taka to comply with Cauvery water-sharing order



The Supreme Court on Monday directed Karnataka to ensure compliance with the Cauvery Water Management Authority's (CWMA) directions on releasing water to Tamil Nadu, while deciding to wait another week to assess whether the state continues to honour the water-sharing order, noting that Tamil Nadu currently had sufficient water and no immediate intervention was required. The court fixed the matter for hearing after a week, seeking an updated status on the release of Cauvery water by Karnataka. The development comes days after the CWMA endorsed the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's direction that Karnataka release 12,000 cusecs of water a day to Tamil Nadu for 15 days from August 13. Tamil Nadu had approached the top court alleging that Karnataka had willfully failed to comply even with the earlier direction to release 3,500 cusecs a day from July 29. —APB

SPORT | IN TEST CRICKET

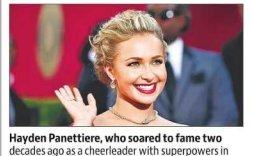
Jadeja in elite club: 350 wickets, 4k runs



Ravindra Jadeja on Monday joined the elite club of players with 350 Test wickets and 4,000 runs, reaching the mark during the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle. The elite club is led by Kapil Dev, who has 5,248 runs and 434 wickets in 131 Tests, followed by Ian Botham with 5,200 runs and 383 wickets in 102 matches. The most recent is Daniel Vettori, who finished with 4,530 runs and 362 wickets in 113 Tests. Nearly 38 but supremely fit, it won't be too much to assume that Jadeja could eventually top this elite list. Jadeja now has 351 scalps and 4,095 runs. Jadeja, with 90 Tests, is also an outlier — not merely because he has joined the club faster, but because he has done so while playing in an era of relentless international cricket and multiple formats. —APB

WORLD | HAYDEN PANETTIERE

Star of 'Heroes' and 'Nashville' dies at 36



Hayden Panettiere, who soared to fame two decades ago as a cheerleader with superpowers in the TV show 'Heroes' and won country music success playing a singer on 'Nashville', has died. She was 36. Police said Panettiere was found unresponsive in an apartment in Greenville, South Carolina, shortly before 2pm on Sunday. Lifesaving measures were performed but she was pronounced dead at the scene. No cause of death has been provided. There were no signs of foul play or suspicious circumstances, police said in a statement. The television star had been open about her struggles with alcohol addiction and depression, including after the birth of her daughter with Ukrainian boxer Vladimir Kitschko in 2014. 'It is with profound sadness that we share the tragic passing of our beloved Hayden', her father, Skip Panettiere, said in a statement. —AP

Taliban pushes for closer India ties at 'Victory Day' event

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: The Taliban regime of Afghanistan used its first ever public reception on Indian soil on Monday to send out a message of deeper engagement that builds on the shared past of the two countries and contributes to regional stability and connectivity. Standing on a stage with the flags of India and the Taliban, charge d'affaires Noor Ahmed Noor outlined the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan's foreign policy based on 'balanced engagement' and non-interference, and plans to forge greater political trust and an economic partnership with India. The event was held to commemorate the fifth anniversary of Victory Day or the Taliban's return to power in Kabul on August 15, 2021. The Indian government, which does not officially recognise the Taliban government, was represented at the event by Anand Prakash, the joint secretary heading the Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran division of the external affairs ministry.

Noor, who spoke in Pashto and had his remarks translated into English, noted the 'significant progress' in India-Afghanistan ties based on mutual respect, political engagement and shared interests. 'We believe that stronger political trust, economic partnership and continued engagement between Afghanistan and India will not only benefit both countries but will also make an important contribution to regional stability, connectivity, and shared prosperity,' he said.

Diplomatic contacts have expanded, embassies and consulates have become more active and high-level delegations have exchanged visits, while 'constructive understanding' has developed in political, economic and humanitarian cooperation, he said. Visits by foreign minister Amir Khan Muttaqi and other ministers have led to understandings in various areas and expanded cooperation, Noor said, while also highlighting the connections dating back several centuries in trade, transit and a shared cultural heritage.

The ancient cities of Afghanistan, such as Kabul, Herat and Kandahar, welcomed Indian traders and caravans, while Indian cities such as Delhi and Lahore benefited from the influence of Afghan



Taliban charge d'affaires Noor Ahmed Noor speaks during the reception on Monday.

scholars, poets and Sufis," he said. "In the political sphere as well, the two countries influenced one another in their struggles for freedom and independence from British colonial rule. This is our shared past, from which we draw inspiration for a better future," he said. Noor thanked India's leadership and external affairs minister S Jaishankar for 'their support in protecting and respecting the international rights' of Afghanistan. "We also appreciate their emphasis at international forums on the need to ensure Afghanistan's legitimate international rights. We hope that greater attention and practical efforts will be made in this regard," he said.

Afghanistan's foreign policy is based on the principles of balanced engagement, mutual respect, non-interference and shared interests, and the country seeks 'positive, constructive, pragmatic and sustainable' ties with all countries, Noor said. "We believe that Afghanistan's stability is not only a success for Afghans; it is also an important opportunity for economic growth, trade, energy, transit and security across the entire region," he added.

Among the handful of countries that were represented at the event by their ambassadors were Bhutan, Iran, Eritrea, Jamaica, Niger, Palestine and Serbia. The event was also attended by diplomats of countries such as China, Russia, Qatar, Iraq, Oman and the United Arab Emirates. Though diplomats from Western and European countries were invited to the reception, they were conspicuous by their absence. While Muttaqi's visit in October 2025 had triggered a controversy as women journalists were not invited to his first news conference in New Delhi, several women reporters were part of the reception.

₹1.9k-cr deal signed to lease 2 MQ-9B drones

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NEW DELHI: The defence ministry on Monday said it signed a ₹1,943-crore contract with US firm General Atomics Aeronautical Systems to lease two MQ-9B Sea Guardian high-altitude, long-endurance remotely piloted aircraft systems to boost the navy's intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance (ISR) capabilities in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR).

The two remotely piloted aircraft (RPA) are being leased for 30 months, it said. The navy already operates two such systems, leased from the US in 2020 for assured surveillance of the IOR. The platforms are based at naval air station Rajali in Tamil Nadu. Equipped with advanced sys-

tems, state-of-the-art sensors and sophisticated payloads, the MQ-9Bs will significantly enhance the Indian Navy's maritime domain awareness capabilities, the defence ministry said. The systems will provide persistent intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance coverage over vast areas of the maritime domain, strengthening the country's ability to monitor and respond to threats in the IOR, it added.

In 2024, India signed a deal worth \$3.5 billion with the US to acquire 32 MQ-9B drones to boost its defence preparedness, primarily with an eye on China. Fifteen drones will be for the navy, and eight each for the army and the Indian Air Force. The deliveries are expected to begin in 2026.

Trump scales back S Korea drills

US president Donald Trump's decision to scale back joint military drills with South Korea has cast a shadow over the alliance amid the continuing North Korean threat

A PULLBACK AT THE TITH HOUR

The annual Ulchi Freedom Shield drills began Monday and are scheduled to run until August 27. Hours before they began, Trump ordered defence secretary Pete Hegseth to 'substantially reduce' them, calling the exercises an inappropriate signal to North Korea. He also cited South Korea's refusal to help the US in its efforts to denuclearise Iran. Trump took a similar step in 2018, suspending that year's major drills after his summit with Kim Jong Un.



North Korean leader Kim Jong Un and US President Donald Trump during a meeting in 2019. —APB

HISTORY OF JOINT PREPAREDNESS

The combined exercises began soon after the Korean War ended with an armistice in 1953, evolving to improve interoperability and command coordination between US and South Korean forces. Over time, they shifted from live-fire training towards computer-simulated missile, cyber and other attacks, adapting to changing threats from North Korea. This year's drills include drones, GPS disruption and cyberattacks, reflecting lessons from North Korean troops fighting in Ukraine.

A RISKY CUT?

Experts warn that scaling back the exercises could weaken alliance coordination and deterrence. They said the cost savings would be marginal, while reducing the drills could slow South Korea's assumption of greater responsibility for its defence.



South Korean and US troops during a joint drill in 2025. —GETTY IMAGES

A DIVIDED PENINSULA

North and South Korea remain technically at war because the 1953 armistice was never replaced by a peace treaty. The two sides remain separated by the heavily fortified DMZ (Demilitarised Zone). In the past, Washington and Seoul have described the drills as defensive even as Pyongyang calls them rehearsals for invasion.



Map not to scale

Quest to regain movement, one robot at a time

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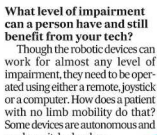
ZURICH: At first glance, Dr Robert Riemer's exoskeleton looks like armor from the Marvel franchise Iron Man. In the Hollywood franchise, a quirky scientist Tony Stark creates an exosuit to enhance his human ability. While Stark wears a hardened armor to fight bad guys, Dr Riemer's exosuit, called a Myosuit, is made of soft, flexible lightweight material and helps paralyzed patients stand and walk.

HT talked to Dr Riemer at his lab on the future of assistive robotics and when will could see paralysed patients using robots to stand, walk and run. Edited excerpts:

What level of impairment can a person have and still benefit from your tech?
Though the robotic devices can work for almost any level of impairment, they need to be operated using either a remote, joystick or a computer. How does a patient with no limb mobility do that? Some devices are autonomous and can be switched on by a caretaker. Others require mechanical controllers like joysticks. In case of complete paralysis, we need to create a brain-computer interface, but that is not easy to apply or reliable.

There's a unique challenge in building robotics for the disabled. You've to reliably understand a disabled patient's desire, and translate that into safe, comfortable machine motion. What's the hardest technical problem in reading nerve or muscle signals?
Assistive robotics are about understanding the intention of a

disabled person than raw mechanical engineering. How do we know if a person wants to run or take steps down to the ground floor, and create a machine that follows that intention? To do that, we need to make the patient wear an electrodes cap that can get a signal of intention directly from the brain. But it's not aesthetic or comfortable for patients to wear for long in some cases and then needs a charge. That's not enough if you're developing an exoskeleton for a patient who needs to wear it for a whole day. Weight is another challenge. Our exoskeleton is about five kilograms in weight. That's not feasible to wear all day long. Batteries and motors are the heaviest part of an exoskeleton which need to become lighter and last longer.



Dr Robert Riemer, who helped restore physical function in people with disabilities. —PHOTO

How long before we see exoskeletons in our daily life? How much will they cost?
The large and bulky exoskeletons that came out 10-15 years ago were heavy, slow and expensive. New devices such as MoGo or HyperSkel came out that are very lightweight, agile, and affordable for individuals. But it will take many years till you see any adoption by the market and society.

More than that exosuit itself, your focus is on how humans change their behaviour when they suddenly walk using your wearable robot. What's the most memorable thing that a patient has said to you?
Many people are so emotional when the first time they can stand up from a wheelchair wearing an exosuit. They hadn't stood up for years. "I can see my children eye-to-eye level," one told me. It is amazing to see their happiness at the fact that they can stand from the wheelchair.



Dr Robert Riemer, who helped restore physical function in people with disabilities. —PHOTO



Dr Robert Riemer, who helped restore physical function in people with disabilities. —PHOTO

What's the thing that surprises you the most about assistive technology as a field of robotics?
The polarization in our society. Many people are anxious about the technology. It can enhance, make patients lose control or be used in the military. These fears need to be addressed by engineers and researchers like us. Others believe that the technology will solve everything, which again is an extreme thought.

Realistically, what will we see in this technology in the next five years?
Power density of motors and batteries will continue to improve. Materials are getting better and will get more intelligent and easier to be used by patients. Ergonomics will also improve, but we are still away from mass adoption of this technology till health insurance includes wearable robotics as allowable medical devices.

As you said, a technology can also be used for riskier propositions. Like in Iron Man, an exosuit can be used in soldier augmentation systems where able-bodied people enhance their

PICK OF THE DAY
The other challenge is to convince engineers and technicians to spend time with people with impairments and the clinical staff who work with them. There are challenges and limitations that exist even in the best prostheses, orthoses and wheelchairs in the world. Engineers must understand the patients to build a technology that



Shweta Tanuja is an author and columnist based in Bengaluru. She tracks the evolving relationship between science, technology and modern society.

MY BENGALURU

Comply with Cauvery water release order: C

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday directed Karnataka to ensure compliance with the Cauvery Water Management Authority's (CWMA) directions on releasing water to Tamil Nadu, while deciding to wait another week to assess whether the state continues to honour the water-sharing order, noting that Tamil Nadu currently had sufficient water and no immediate intervention was required.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta fixed the matter for hearing after a week, seeking an updated status on the release of Cauvery water by Karnataka.

The bench was hearing Tamil Nadu's plea seeking implementation of the CWMA's decision directing Karnataka to release water to Tamil Nadu, told the court that Karnataka was not complying with the authority's directions and that Tamil Nadu was "not getting the water", leaving it unable to release water to farmers.

"In spite of the directions of CWMA, that is not being complied with and we are not seeing the water. We are not able to release any water to the agriculturalists. It can't be that they will keep all the waters," Vaidyanathan submitted.

He said Karnataka's reservoirs had 76% live storage as of Monday morning and, under the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal award, of TMC should have come to Tamil Nadu, whereas the state had received only 14 TMC. Even assuming a 10% reduction in the Vaidyanathan said, Tamil Nadu should have received 55.29% of the water and there was a backlog of about 20 TMC.

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: Karnataka transport minister Byrathi Suresh on Monday hinted at a ticket price hike in government buses, citing an increase in diesel prices.

Speaking to reporters here, the minister said the public transport fare regulatory committee headed by former IAS officer Anil Kumar Tiwari has been formed to look into it, which will submit a report on the ticket prices.

"We have formed a committee under the chairmanship of Anil Tiwari. It has already been about 20 days, and he has been visiting all the places and all four transport corporations. He will submit a report," the Minister said.

The minister said he would discuss with the Chief Minister the bus fare hike after Tiwari submits the report.

"We will place the report before the Cabinet and then take a decision," he added, explaining further, Suresh said since the

THE BENCH WAS HEARING TN'S PLEA SEEKING IMPLEMENTATION OF THE CWMA'S DECISION DIRECTING KARNATAKA TO RELEASE WATER TO THE STATE

Appearing for Karnataka, senior advocate Shyam Divan disputed Tamil Nadu's allegation of non-compliance, saying the state had not only complied with the earlier CWMA direction to release 3,500 cuses a day but had substantially exceeded it.

Divan told the bench that the first direction had remained in force until August 11 and Karnataka was required to ensure a flow of 3,500 cuses at the interstate border. He added that water released from the Krishna Raja Sagar reservoir took about 48 hours to reach the downstream point and protocols had to be followed before releases could be made.

"As of this morning the flow has exceeded the 12,000 cuses which has been directed in the last order," Divan said, adding that instructions had been issued to ensure that the 12,000-cuses flow was maintained throughout the day.

The bench asked Divan whether, according to Karnataka, it had complied with the CWMA direction requiring a flow of 12,000 cuses a day from August 12.

Divan responded that there was a shortage in the first four and five days but that the flow crossed the mandated level from the 12th. He submitted that the CWMA requirement on August

17 was 12,000 cuses and the flow had reached 12,607 cuses. "We are not releasing any water, it is because God has been kind and flow has come. As of this morning it has exceeded 12,000 and those gates have been opened," Divan maintained.

He assured the court that Karnataka would endeavour to maintain the 12,000-cuses flow directed by the CWMA, though it would be "very difficult" for the state.

Divan also submitted that two expert bodies had applied their minds to the issue and issued directions. Therefore, the role of the Supreme Court should be "very minimal".

The development comes days after the CWMA endorsed the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's direction that Karnataka release 12,000 cuses of water a day to Tamil Nadu for 15 days from August 13.

Tamil Nadu had approached the Supreme Court alleging that Karnataka had willfully failed to comply even with the earlier direction to release 3,500 cuses a day from July 29. It had sought directions to ensure that the stipulated flow reached the interstate border at Billigundlu.

Karnataka, in a reply filed before the court, had disputed Tamil Nadu's calculation of a shortfall and said it had in fact released substantially more water than mandated between July 29 and August 10. It said 86,797 cuses had reached Billigundlu against the required 45,500 cuses during that period. The state had also maintained that the 2026-27 water year was a "drought year" and questioned the basis of Tamil Nadu's claim for an additional 26,594 TMC as its pro-rata entitlement.

JDS' LEADER HELD FOR ASSAULTING POLICE IN B'LURU
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BENGALURU: Karnataka JDS' general secretary Manjunath C was arrested for allegedly assaulting and assaulting police constable here, police said on Monday.

Manjunath alias Gottigere Manjanna (65) is a resident of Gottigere here, the police said. The incident occurred on August 16 at about 3 PM, while police constable Arun Manjunath C was on duty at B G Road, Gottigere Junction, police said.

A video showing Manjunath grabbing the constable by his collar and kicking him, went viral on social media, drawing widespread public outrage.

According to police, when the traffic constable signalled Manjunath's car to stop while regulating traffic, he got out of his vehicle and allegedly abused the constable in filthy language. He then punched him in the face, causing bleeding injuries and obstructed him from discharging his official duties, and fled from the spot.

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BENGALURU: The Bharatiya Janata Party and the Janata Dal (Secular) disrupted proceedings in both Houses of the Karnataka legislature on Monday, demanding the dismissal of minister B Nagendra over his alleged involvement in the multi-core roped embezzlement matter in the Karnataka Maharishi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation (KMSTD), and the killing of three suspected poachers in a forest in Hanur taluk of Chamarajanagar district recently.

When legislative Assembly speaker GS Patil announced that the question hour will be taken up, opposition leader in the Assembly R Ashoka and his colleague V Sunil Kumar, raising Nagendra's issue, said they will not allow the proceedings to continue until the minister is sacked. "How can we participate when a corrupt minister is sitting here?" Ashoka asked. Bengaluru development minister Krishna Byregowda said the opposition should give prior notice to raise the matter and was wasting the time of the House. "They have raised the issue to push up internal differences in their party," he maintained. Nagendra was inducted into chief minister DK Shivakumar's cabinet on August 3 and

holds the portfolio of planning and statistics. He had resigned from the Siddaramaiah cabinet in June 2024 following allegations of misappropriation of funds amounting to ₹94.73 crore. The scandal came to light after P Chandrashekar, working as an accounts superintendent in KMSTD, died by suicide on May 26 in Shivamogga district. The scandal came to light after P Chandrashekar, working as an accounts superintendent in KMSTD, died by suicide on May 26 in Shivamogga district.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) had arrested Nagendra in the scam case in July 2024, and a Special Court in Bengaluru in October that year, granted bail to the MLA from Ballari. Nagendra

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) President BK Hariprasad on Monday compared the Rashtriya Swamasevak Sangh (RSS) to international terrorist groups like Jaish-e-Mohammed and the Taliban while targeting them over patriotism and legal registration status.

Addressing the press conference, Hariprasad said, "There is a difference between Jaish-e-Mohammed, Taliban, and RSS because all three are not registered in India."

On Kerala VC Mohan Kunnummal's remarks regarding the Vande Mataram controversy, the KPCC president said, "...He has rightly directed this at the RSS because they never sing Vande Mataram, nor do they sing the national anthem or hoist the tricolour flag."

The remarks followed an FIR filed against senior Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi alleging disruption of the rendition of "Vande Mataram," alongside recent remarks by Kerala VC Mohan Kunnummal at an RSS gathering criticising those who oppose the national song.

Hariprasad's comments reinforce Karnataka Home Minister Priyankh Kharage's recent demand for the RSS to publicly clarify under which Indian laws it holds property, bank accounts, and



BIP MLAs protest against the government in the Legislative Council during the monsoon session in Bengaluru on Monday.

has been named in the charge-sheet by the ED and CBI in connection with the case. Sunil Kumar said the opposition will not press for Nagendra's resignation, if he admits that the money allegedly siphoned off was used to fund his Assembly elections from Ballari in 2023 and also given to the Congress high command. Intervening deputy chief minister G Parameshwara asked the opposition to furnish proof that money was spent during the Assembly polls.

After two adjournments, when the opposition refused to relent and staged a dharna in the House, the speaker decided to go ahead with the business amid their sloganeering. The question hour and issues to be raised were taken up with the opposition

tion shouting slogans in the well of the House. Later, the House was adjourned for the day. Killing of suspected forest poachers: Even as the ruling Congress government ordered a magisterial inquiry into the killing of three suspected poachers in a forest in Hanur taluk of Chamarajanagar district by forest department officials in the early hours of 15, August, the BJP and JD(S) demanded a judicial probe. They sought the resignation of forest minister Ramnagappa Reddy holding him morally responsible for the killings. Leaders of opposition in both Houses of the legislature R Ashoka and Chaluvala Narayanaiah demanded a probe into the families of the three deceased whom they claimed were "murdered" by the forest department personnel. Ashoka said a fourth person, who was injured and admitted to the K R Hospital in Mysuru had disappeared.

The government was silent on the injured person's statement. "If the three persons who were killed were forest poachers like Veerappa, why were the local farmers protesting in their support?" he asked. He referred to Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay condemning the incident and questioning the killings as the deceased were in the support of the forest department.

After two adjournments, when the opposition refused to relent and staged a dharna in the House, the speaker decided to go ahead with the business amid their sloganeering. The question hour and issues to be raised were taken up with the opposition

government has not given a clarification," he maintained. In his reply in both the Houses, Reddy identified the deceased as Anurag Swamy (50 years), John Rose Peter (42 years) and Kumar alias Savarivayal (32 years), residents of villages on the fringes of Cauvery Wildlife Reserve. The fourth suspected poacher Mahimadani (45 years) was injured. He dismissed C B Suresh Babu, JD(S) MLA's claim that one of the deceased's family members had said he had gone looking for their missing guns in the forest. "If they were looking for missing guns, why were the suspected poachers carrying utensils and cooking ingredients?" he asked.

Reading out the forest department report, Reddy said two teams spotted four people carrying an unlicensed country gun and four bags of deer meat weighing 34.25 kg after hunting in the forest.

The forest department said it opened fire in self defence from a side action gun, which caused multiple injuries to the suspected poachers in an unlicensed country gun and four bags of deer meat weighing 34.25 kg after hunting in the forest.

Man, 5-year-old son found dead at home; wife being questioned

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BENGALURU: A 35-year-old private company employee and his 5-year-old son were found dead under suspicious circumstances at their residence in Guddu Beasavapura, under Chikballanavara police station limits, on Monday morning, police said, adding that they were questioning the wife as part of the probe.

The deceased have been identified as Abhinandan, 35, a native of Kunigal, and his son Yaduvr, 5. Abhinandan was married to his wife, Harini, for 6 years and lived with his son. According to police, the incident came to light after Harini contacted the police helpline on Monday morning.

She reportedly told the police that the family had gone to a relative's house. "We had gone to a relative's house and returned on Sunday evening. When I woke up on Monday morning, I found my husband and son lying unresponsive," Harini reportedly told the police.

Police sent their bodies for postmortem examination. Senior police officers said minor external injury marks were noticed on the body. The exact cause of death is expected to be established after the postmortem reports are received. Police have also seized the

mobile phones of both persons as part of the investigation. Officers are examining their call records, messages and other available digital evidence to establish the sequence of events before their deaths.

However, the case took a turn after Abhinandan's mother approached the police and lodged a complaint alleging that her son and grandson had been murdered.

Based on the complaint and other suspicious circumstances noticed at the house, police registered a murder case and began a detailed investigation. Bengaluru North-West Division DCP Nagesh D. said investigators had noticed several suspicious aspects at the residence and that the police is investigating the cause of footage at the house.

However, officers found that the footage had not been saved. Police are questioning family members, including Abhinandan's wife, as part of the probe.

State expands food safety inspections, launches QR code for public complaints

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BENGALURU: Karnataka minister U T Khader on Monday launched a QR code system to report food and drug safety violations and said inspections would be expanded to schools, educational institutions, railway canteens, flight catering services and other establishments. He felicitated Food Safety and Drug Administration Commissioner Srinivas K and his team for their recent state-wide inspections.

Speaking to reporters here, the health minister said the department had acted promptly after being directed to conduct the inspections.

"Our government has earned a good name among the public because of our staff's efficient work. We want to recognise, encourage and support them because they are the face of the government," he said.

Khader said the newly launched QR code would be displayed outside hotels and other public places and shared on social media platforms.



UT Khader

"Going forward, we do not want to wait for complaints to reach us. We cannot be everywhere and inspect everything ourselves. Therefore, we have developed a QR code, which with information or a complaint about food safety or drug and pharmacy-related violations can be used to report the matter to us," he said, claiming that Karnataka was the first state to introduce such a mechanism.

The minister said a toll-free number and a dedicated call centre would also be set up. "We will provide a number up and set up a dedicated team to handle all the calls and respond to any area with a complaint, the

team can go there, conduct an inspection and take appropriate action. The aim is to provide complaints with easier and more direct access to the department," he said.

He said 30 teams comprising officials from different districts and pharmacy-related violations were found, while establishments with serious violations were sealed.

The purpose of these inspections is to ensure that we do not let anyone, shut down their business or punish them. Our primary objective is first to make them understand what they are doing wrong," the minister said.

"At the same time, we want to create awareness among the public that everything is not necessarily safe. When people go to a hotel or any other place to eat, they should think about these issues carefully and not take food safety for granted," he added. Several food items and products were seized during the inspections, he said, adding that the exercise would be taken to the grassroots level.

Khader particularly warned PG accommodation owners against compromising on food and safety standards.

"We are particularly concerned about PG accommodation centres. Therefore, my message to all PG owners is simple: treat the students and young men and women staying with you like your own children. If you are willing to provide them food and care in the same manner as you would to your own children, they should you run a PG centre. Otherwise, do not run a PG centre. Nobody has the right to make money from the suffering of young people and students," he said.

Civil society groups urge DKS to extend SIR process by 3 months

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: Several civil society organisations in Karnataka on Monday urged chief minister D K Shivakumar to intervene in the SIR of electoral rolls, alleging large-scale deletions and omissions exceeding 60 per cent in nearly 3,000 booths.

In a letter to the CM, the organisations claimed that 10.9 million voters were on the Absent, Shifted, Duplicate, Dead and Other list, while nearly half of Bengaluru's voters could disappear from the electoral rolls, with deletions exceeding 60 per cent in nearly 3,000 booths.

They claimed that many elderly persons had been marked as 'dead' people who had gone elsewhere for work had been classified as 'absent', and those who could not properly fill out enumeration forms had been placed under 'others' and marked for deletion.

The organisations alleged that people who had shifted their residence after 2002 were not being provided enumeration forms.



DK Shivakumar

In the letter, the organisations alleged that Form 8, meant for voters seeking changes in address, was not being provided, while existing voters with deletions exceeding 60 per cent in nearly 3,000 booths.

The letter said the timelines were inadequate for BLOs to visit households, identify and explain the forms, collect them

and upload the details. The organisations urged the Karnataka government to seek a three-month extension of the enumeration exercise and conduct the entire exercise over one year.

They called for fresh door-to-door visits by BLOs in all-door-to-door visits, either by the Election Commission or the Karnataka government.

If the Election Commission does not agree to the measures, the organisations urged the government to discuss the matter in the Assembly, pass a resolution and urge the Election Commission of India to take the required steps.

They suggested approaching the Supreme Court, if necessary, to protect the interests of Karnataka and ensure that eligible voters are not excluded from the electoral rolls.

COUNCIL BERATES PURIFICATION RITUAL AT KHARGE RALLY IN U'KHAND

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka Legislative Council on Monday passed a condemnation resolution denouncing the Shuddhikaran of Ramula Maidan stage set for August 18, 2026, organised by Sri Ram Sena after Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally on August 8.

Shri Ram Sena allegedly performed a 'Havan' (ritual) using Ganga water at the venue on August 10, two days after Kharge addressed a political rally there on August 8. The ritual triggered political outrage, with Congress leaders alleging that it reflected a discriminatory mindset against Dalits.

In this connection, Congress MLAs P H Jakappaiah, D Thimmaiah, Thippanna Kamaknour, D T Srinivas, Balkares Banu, Jagadev Gutur and others moved the condemnation resolution. Kharge addressed a rally on August 8, 2026, at the venue on August 10, two days after Kharge addressed a political rally there on August 8. The ritual triggered political outrage, with Congress leaders alleging that it reflected a discriminatory mindset against Dalits.

Vijay unveils full waiver of crop loans up to ₹75k to TN farmers

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C. V. Vijay on Monday announced a full waiver on cooperative crop loans up to ₹75,000 distributed among the state's farmers.

The additional waiver follows the government's May 25 announcement of a complete waiver on crop loans up to ₹50,000 availed by small farmers. In a suo moto statement at the state assembly on Monday, Vijay said the latest waiver would cost the state exchequer ₹953.06 crore. Cooperative crop loans up to ₹75,000 would be waived completely, he said. However, loans between ₹75,000 and ₹1 lakh would be subject to a waiver of up to ₹75,000, while loans above ₹1 lakh would be subject to a ₹35,000 waiver.

"Only in a nation that respects agriculture and accords proper

{ C JOSEPH VIJAY } TAMIL NADU CM

Only in a nation that respects agriculture... can the people live with prosperity and happiness

HT



protection and support to farmers can the people live with prosperity and happiness," said the chief minister.

Considering the representations of farmers' associations across the state, a June 19 order was issued to revise the scheme, he said. "Under this, full loan waiver was announced for those

who had borrowed up to ₹75,000 and a waiver of ₹35,000 for those who had borrowed above ₹75,000, thereby waiving cooperative crop loans to help 14.44 lakh (14.44 million) farmers," he said. The bank accounts of 13.3 million farmers received a cumulative ₹5,267 crore under

this waiver on July 31.

"₹28,264 farmers who have taken crop loans between ₹75,000 and ₹1 lakh will receive a waiver of up to ₹75,000 each. This will enable them to get an additional waiver of up to ₹40,000 over and above the waiver amount already received," said the chief minister.

Although crop loans were waived in the past, amounts payable by the government to co-operatives were not waived. A gap of 4-5 years, he said, adding that the amount under crop loans waived in 2021 was limited to cooperative banks in 12 instalments between 2021 and 2026.

As per the Reserve Bank of India's November 28, 2025 guidelines on the operational procedure of government loan waiver schemes, the government must remit the full waiver amount completely to cooperative banks within 45 to 60 days

of the waiver being availed. The latest waiver followed considerations on current financial resources, he said.

Farmers association across the state welcomed the announcement. "This announcement will meet the expectations of smaller and marginal farmers. We want the government to announce a full waiver of crop loans to all farmers. The government has announced a slab and based on that, they are waiving off the loans. For example, a farmer can only avail the waiver if he has loaned an amount of ₹75,000 to ₹1 lakh. But this will help only 50% of farmers in the state," a member of Tamil Nadu Vivasangal Sangam, told HT. He noted that a complete waiver on farm loans was mentioned in the Tamil Nadu Vetri Kazhagam's assembly election manifesto, where the TVK had announced that cooperative crop loans to farmers owing up to 5 acres would be waived completely.

EX-COURT STAFFER GETS 37-YEAR JAIL FOR DOCTORING ACCIDENT CLAIMS

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CHENNAI: The chief judicial magistrate court in Kallakurichi sentenced a former court staffer to 37 years in prison for misappropriating ₹38 lakh by manipulating judges' signatures and also manipulating Motor Accident Claims Tribunal cases settled between 2012 and 2014.

The convict was identified as Arulselvi, who used to serve as a sheristadar's assistant at the same court, fraudulently reused the case numbers of Motor Accident Claims cases that she had already been settled and closed, misappropriated court funds and transferred the amounts to the bank accounts of her son Varatharajan and her associates. Tamilanar Varatharajan and Tamilanar were awarded 27 years imprisonment each.

According to CB-CD, Villupuram, the fraud came to light during an inspection of Motor Accident Claims cases disposed between 2012 and 2014, ordered by the Madras high court.

7.3 million names not included in Tgana draft rolls

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: As many as 7.3 million names have not been included in Telangana's draft electoral rolls published by the Election Commission of India (ECI) on Monday as part of the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

Another 9.2 million electors will be issued notices over anomalies or failure to establish a link with the 2002 rolls during the ongoing SIR. Telangana chief electoral officer (CEO) C. Sudharshan Reddy said.

He said that about 7.3 million names were in the absent, shifted, dead or duplicate list. Genuine electors can still have their names included in the electoral rolls during the claims and objections period from August 17 to September 16 by submitting Form 6 along with the prescribed declaration form, the CEO said.

"The enumeration forms of 7,339,224 electors, accounting for 21.70%, could not be collected and uploaded," Reddy said, adding the revision was aimed at maximising elector participation, not at indiscriminately deleting names from the rolls.

According to the CEO, the SIR exercise revealed that 45,18,961 voters, or 16.99% of the total, had permanently shifted residence and were categorised as migrants.

"These voters were found to be no longer residing at the addresses mentioned in the present electoral rolls. In several cases, field-level verification indicated that voters had moved permanently to other locations," Reddy said.

Apart from migrated voters, booth-level officers (BLOs) identified 922,230 voters who had died, 1,125,546 who were not available at the given addresses or had otherwise become untraceable, and 670,203 who had already enrolled elsewhere. Another 102,294 voters had not submitted their enumeration



C Sudharshan Reddy

forms, the CEO said.

The SIR also detected considerable variation in the digitisation of around 10 lakh enumeration forms collected.

According to official data uploaded on the Telangana CEO website, Yadadri-Bhuvanagiri district topped the state with 94.31% of enumeration forms collected and digitised, while Hyderabad recorded the lowest progress at 58.89%.

Rangareddy and Medchal-Malkajgiri districts, adjacent to the Hyderabad capital city, recorded 65.16% and 63.97% digitisation respectively, the data said.

In Hyderabad, Rangareddy and Medchal-Malkajgiri districts, which account for 28 assembly constituencies, the total number of voters has fallen from around ₹1.4 crore to approximately ₹71 lakh after the completion of SIR. "This means that more than one out of every three voters included in the earlier electoral rolls is currently not reflected in the provisional figures," an official said.

Of the 15 assembly constituencies in Hyderabad district, 10 have recorded a decline of more than 40% in the number of voters. In Rangareddy district, three constituencies logged a reduction of more than 40%. In Medchal-Malkajgiri district, Uppal has recorded a decline of 38.8% among the constituencies in the district.

The CEO said genuine electors can still be added back to the electoral rolls during the claims and objections period (August 17 to September 16) using Form-6 along with the prescribed declaration form.

DMK stages walkout from House after row over 19-yr-old's murder

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Leader of Opposition in the Tamil Nadu assembly Udhayanidhi Stalin on Monday led the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) in a walkout after an intense exchange with the state government over the alleged lynching of a 19-year-old engineering student in Coimbatore on August 10.

The matter arose soon after the House convened for the day, after Stalin moved a special motion to discuss the issue. He claimed that numerous murders had rocked the state in the last week alone. "In Coimbatore, 19-year-old Amudhan was brutally killed. It's not a gang war, it's a murder. He belongs to the SC community," Stalin said.

He alleged that Amudhan was killed after providing information about drug-related activities. He said that his parents had also raised the same allegation. "The drugs should have been seized. The main reason behind Amudhan's death is due to drugs. Their parents spoke to me; they said Amudhan was killed because



LoP Udhayanidhi Stalin leads a DMK walkout from the legislative assembly session at Chennai's Fort St. George on Monday.

he gave a tip-off about the drug menace," he said.

Stalin alleged state negligence on law and order and demanded action against Amudhan's killers. Responding to the LoP, state law minister R. Nirmal Kumar said the incident led to two separate police cases being registered. "Following the death of Amudhan, provisions under the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act were added to the case," he said.

State social justice and backward classes welfare ministers Vanni Arasu and V Sampath

Kumar met the victim's family on August 16. "Orders have been issued to provide initial relief of ₹6 lakh to the family," said Nirmal Kumar. He also reiterated the claim that incident arose out of a gang war and was not related to the drug trade.

"In this case, without any delay, the police registered charges and swiftly arrested the culprits," he said, adding that chief minister C. V. Vijay ordered that the charge sheet be filed within 3 months and progress be monitored regularly.

Seaside graveyard



A worker removes dead jellyfish washed ashore along Kovalam Beach in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday. The phenomenon is reported due to changing tides or rough currents.

KERALA POLICE LOOSENS UNIFORM REGULATIONS FOR PREGNANT COPS

HT Correspondent
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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala Police has relaxed existing norms to allow maternity-friendly uniforms for recently pregnant personnel, officials said on Monday.

The matter was examined against practical difficulties pregnant personnel faced while performing official duties. Standing orders, PHQ circulars, IPS uniform rules and rules in other states were examined.

"In view of the above, it is hereby ordered that women police personnel who are in pregnancy are permitted to wear khaki Salwar Kameez and shawl and sandals during pregnancy," an August 14 circular said.

However, for lady IPS officers, the IPS uniform rules will apply, added the circular.

SIT probe into ghee procurement case going in right direction: HC

Vishnu Varma
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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala high court on Monday said that the SIT probe into the ghee misappropriation case at the Sabarimala temple was proceeding in the proper direction.

The SIT led by Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau SP MJ Sojan submitted a progress report on the probe before the HC division bench of Justices Rja Vijayaraghavan V and KV Jayakumar.

The court noted that certain records were seized from offices of the Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB), which administers the Sabarimala temple, at Sabarimala, Nilakal, Pandalam, Pathanamthitta, Erumeli and Thiruvananthapuram. Records were also seized from offices of the milk cooperative MILMA, which supplied the ghee to the temple.

THE MATTER PERTAINS TO ALLEGED GAPS IN PROCUREMENT OF GHEE TO PREPARE ARAVANA PAYSAM OFFERED AT SABARIMALA

at Pathanamthitta and Thiruvananthapuram. The verification and scrutiny of the records and questioning are being pursued vigorously, the HC was told.

"We direct the officer to ensure that the SIT is left untarnished and that all possible efforts are taken to carry out a comprehensive and foolproof investigation in an expeditious manner," the bench said.

The suo moto case pertains to alleged irregularities in the procurement of ghee to prepare aravana paysam, a traditional offering at the temple.

The Chief Vigilance and Security Officer of TDB had told the court that an e-tendering process was abandoned by TDB officials to favour the procurement of ghee from MILMA on the basis of recommendation of Murari Babu, the then administrative officer, that the cooperative's ghee was of superior quality and less quantity would be required.

The TDB, headed by Prasanna, went on to approve the procurement of 1,65,000 litres of ghee from MILMA at ₹50 per litre during the 2025-26 pilgrimage season. The court was informed that the ghee was procured from MILMA at a higher price while the lowest bidder quoted ₹369 per litre at the same quality. It was found that TDB could have saved ₹22.27 crore if the highest bidder was selected.

The court was also informed that the ghee was procured from MILMA at a higher price while the lowest bidder quoted ₹369 per litre at the same quality. It was found that TDB could have saved ₹22.27 crore if the highest bidder was selected.

The suo moto case pertains to alleged irregularities in the procurement of ghee to prepare aravana paysam, a traditional offering at the temple.

TN proposes new Industrial Corridor to Kerala capital

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu has requested the Centre to consider setting up of a Chennai-Thiruvananthapuram Industrial Corridor

aimed at promoting industrial development and strengthening economic activity along the route, minister S. K. Kesavaiah said. The proposed expansion and strengthening of industrial corridor linkages would help improve connectivity between industrial centres.

Govt hospitals to be on par with pvt ones: Tgana CM

TELANGANA: Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Monday vowed to develop the government-run super specialty hospitals on par with any corporate hospital in the country, providing advanced quality healthcare to the people, who cannot afford expensive treatment at private hospitals. The state would have an additional 10,000 beds at the hospitals by December 2027.

Man sentenced to life for killing his

CONVICTED IN THE

HYDERABAD: A court on Monday sentenced a 45-year-old man to life imprisonment for

committing a crime in a

Collegiate school, in

2016. The X Additional

District and Sessions

Judge, Rajendra Nagar,

convicted the accused

Rupesh Kumar M, a

private employee, and

sentenced him to

undergo life

imprisonment and pay

a fine of ₹25,000. After

a full-fledged trial, the

court subsequently

convicted him and

sentenced him to

undergo life

imprisonment and also

imposed the fine, the

release added.



SPEAKER: AIADMK MLAs' RESIGNATION ACCEPTED ONLY AFTER ENQUIRY

Ayesha Arvind
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu legislative assembly speaker JCD Prabhakar on Monday informed the Madras high court that his acceptance of three AIADMK legislators' resignations was valid, adding that the resignation letters tendered by them were "voluntary, genuine and suffered from no legal or constitutional infirmity," despite a pending request to disqualify them under the anti-defection law.

In an affidavit filed before a bench of CJ SJA Dharmadhikari and Justice Muralidharan, Prabhakar said he personally questioned the three MLAs—S. Jayakumar, Maragatham Kumaravel and P. Sathiyabama—after they handed resignation letters on May 25. The affidavit was filed in compliance with an earlier order of the high court, which is hearing a petition by AIADMK wing leader S. Krishnamurthy and a PIL filed by Desiya Makkal Sakthi Katchi against the decision.

The speaker said he acted in accordance with the proviso to Article 190(3)(b) of the Constitution and Rule 22 of the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly Rules, which govern the resignation of members. He maintained that his inquiry fell within the scope of examination constitutionally contemplated under the proviso to the assembly rules.

{ MONSOON SESSION }

No malpractices in DSC hiring, Andhra govt tells assembly

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: As the four-day monsoon session of the Andhra Pradesh legislature began on Monday, the state government claimed that there were no malpractices in the conduct of 16,347 teachers' recruitments through district selection committees (DSCs) in 2025.

Addressing the state assembly, which was boycotted by the YSRCP, state deputy CM Nara Lokesh said the government took up the recruitment of 16,347 posts, for which 3,36,300 candidates applied. "The recruitment process was completed within 38 days and fair women appointments were made after following vertical and horizontal reservation norms, merit-computerised procedures and multiple levels of grievance redressal," he said.

He said the government had prepared 42,000 questions for the examination covering 13 subjects and conducted the test through the TCS ION platform. Certificate verification was carried out at the district level, while the examination was conducted through the computer-based testing system.

The government also implemented SC sub-categorisation for the examination and expanded the sports quota from 29 categories to 65 in accordance with central norms. Lokesh said the government had introduced DSC recruitment and made the Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) mandatory for qualification.

He said 336 cases filed against the recruitment process were rejected by the DSC recruitment and the process was raised, and the



Nara Lokesh

courts made it clear that vertical and horizontal reservations had to be implemented. He accused the YSRCP of making II "baseless" allegations regarding the recruitment process along caste and religious lines. He challenged former CM Y. S. Jagan Mohan Reddy and other YSRCP leaders to a public debate.

He also questioned the absence of YSRCP members from the assembly. The exercise is being undertaken against the backdrop of questions about whether religious institutions require specialised accounting and financial-control frameworks following allegations of irregularities involving donations received by the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

The proposal is being undertaken against the backdrop of questions about whether religious institutions require specialised accounting and financial-control frameworks following allegations of irregularities involving donations received by the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

As part of the exercise, the TTD has sought the help of the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI). On August

TTD begins total overhaul of accounting, fiscal management systems, say officials

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
 letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), which administers the Lord Venkateswara temple in Tirumala in Tirupati district has begun the exercise an overhaul its accounting and financial management systems, people familiar with the matter said.

The exercise is being undertaken against the backdrop of questions about whether religious institutions require specialised accounting and financial-control frameworks following allegations of irregularities involving donations received by the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

As part of the exercise, the TTD has sought the help of the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI). On August

THE STUDY WILL COVER THE ENTIRE ACCOUNTING CYCLE OF THE TTD, FROM REVENUE COLLECTIONS TO THE FINAL BALANCE SHEET

5, the ICAI representatives headed by its president P. Prasanna Kumar held discussions with TTD executive officer Muddala Ravichandran and other officials on taking up accounting reforms, financial reporting and governance.

Prasanna Kumar said the ICAI's Accounting Research Foundation (ARF) has begun a comprehensive study of the TTD's existing accounting and audit framework and will prepare a project report recommending measures to strengthen financial reporting, internal controls, auditing and governance.

The initiative is aimed at bringing the TTD's nearly three-

decade-old accounting manual in line with contemporary accounting standards, digital systems and global best practices. "A preliminary study had already commenced and the institute expected to complete it and submit its report within 100 days," Kumar said.

The study will cover the entire accounting cycle of the TTD, from revenue collections and payments to preparation of financial statements and the balance sheet. An expert team from the ICAI ARF is also undertaking field-level assessment and collecting preliminary financial information, including trial balances and account records, to understand the TTD's existing practices.

According to Prasanna Kumar, the TTD already had a comprehensive system and that its financial operations were being managed through ERP (Enterprise Resource Planning) but its underlying accounting manual is based on a system that has been in use for nearly two decades.

"We shall take it to the next

level since the current one is an old system," Kumar said, adding that the exercise was therefore intended to bridge the gap between the existing accounting framework and the technology-driven financial processes currently followed by the temple administration.

The study will also examine risk management and internal control mechanisms, which are essential to prevent financial leakages. "There should be a strong risk management and internal system, and even if there is any small deviation or lapse, then pilferage would happen," the ICAI president said.

The TTD official quoted above said the proposed overhaul could have implications beyond Tirumala. "Once completed and implemented, the accounting framework developed in collaboration with ICAI could potentially serve as a reference model for other major temple institutions, particularly those managing substantial revenues, assets, donations and public-facing financial operations," he added.

Killed in fire at hotel in Bengal temple town

HT Correspondent
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KOLKATA: Nine people, including two children, were killed in a fire at a hotel at Tarapith, a temple town in West Bengal's Birbhum district, early on Monday, officials said, adding that a person was arrested for alleged lapses in the maintenance of the fire-fighting system at the establishment.

According to officials, the fire broke out around 4.30 am at the reception area on the ground floor of the four-storey hotel, when most of the guests were asleep. The blaze spread rapidly through decorative and wooden materials inside the hotel, with smoke billowing to the upper floors and trapping several guests in their rooms, they added.

Overall, 43 people were rescued. Of them nine have died. While five of the deceased were from Meghalaya, four were from Alipurduar and Jalpaiguri districts in West Bengal," said Birbhum superintendent of police (SP) Vidit Raj Bhundesh.

The deceased included two children, aged eight and ten. Some people sustained burn injuries, while others fell ill due to asphyxiation, officials said, adding the injured were taken to a state-run hospital and later discharged after treatment. Soon after the incident, fire tenders were rushed to the spot and brought the blaze under control.

Many of the guests at the hotel were devotees who had come to offer prayers at the Tarapith Temple — dedicated to Goddess Tara — on the last Monday of Shravan month.

Officials said the exact cause of the fire is yet to be ascertained. However, hotel officials claimed while talking to reporters that the fire started by a short circuit near the hotel's reception after an electrical component of the power supply system caught fire.

Preliminary investigations revealed that the hotel's front door access was cut due to the fire in the reception area. Emergency exits on each floor were locked. The terrace door was also blocked with plywood, trapping the smoke, the SP said.

"There was a back door which was locked. The terrace door was also blocked. This trapped the

How the events unfolded



- **4:30 am:** Fire possibly breaks out in the hotel's reception area
- **5:16 am:** Tarapith fire station receives an alert over the phone
- **5:25 am:** The first fire tender from Tarapith reaches the spot and begins firefighting operations
- **5:40 am:** A second fire tender from Rampurhat and an ambulance join the operation
- **5:50 am:** Fire brigade officials enter the building through a second-floor balcony using ladders and rescue the first person
- **7:20 am:** All those trapped are rescued, and the fire is brought under control. The search-and-rescue operation is called off

5 FROM VILLAGE IN MEGHALAYA AMONG VICTIMS

HT Correspondents
letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA/SHILLONG: A pall of gloom descended on Dala, a hamlet in Meghalaya's West Garo Hills district, as five of its residents were among the nine people killed in a hotel fire at Tarapith in West Bengal's Birbhum district on Monday.

"An 11-member team from Dala had come to Tarapith on Sunday. Five have been killed. They include a couple and their son and a man and his son," said a police officer.

The deceased from Dala were identified as Buran Madak, 45, his 10-year-old son Shivraj, Rajendra Nath, 45, his wife Asha Nath, 32, and their eight-year-old son Ashunath. The two children were students of class 3 and 5 in Woodlawn Secondary School, which has declared a holiday on Tuesday to mourn their deaths.

Meghalaya CM Conrad K Sangma said in a statement, "On behalf of the people of Meghalaya, I extend my deepest condolences to the families of the deceased in this hour of grief." He also announced ex-gratia of ₹2 lakh for the next of kin of each of the deceased.

The other four deceased in the incident were identified as Subir Saha (44), Rajesh Sahu (33), Adhikari Santanu (33), and Kamal Roy and Anil Pal (both in their 40s) — all residents of Alipurduar and Jalpaiguri districts of West Bengal, officials said.

Saha's family members said they could not muster the courage to break the tragic news to his wife, Rakhi. "We don't know what to tell her. They have a two and a half-year-old son. Subir was the only earning member," said Subir's brother Sujit Saha, told HT over phone from Alipurduar.

Saha, who visited Deoghar in Jharkhand every year during the month of Shravan and paid obeisance at the Tarapith Temple on his way back, was accompanied by his wife and Anil Pal this year. Pal, who was the sole earner in his family, also died in the incident. Rajesh Sahu, 33, from Duggurji in Jalpaiguri district, also succumbed to his injuries.

Timeline of the tragedy

- **6:30 am**
Huge crowd heads towards the famous Ashok Dham temple through the pathways along the agricultural fields
- **6:39 am**
An 11KV electricity pole falls near the crowd
- **6:40 am**
Panic grips over a rumour that live electricity was flowing through the field, leading to stampede
- **6:45 am**
Rescue operation begins
- **7:20 am**
Seven people are declared dead and 23 injured



7 devotees killed, 25 injured in stampede near Bihar temple

Avinash Kumar
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PATNA: Seven women devotees, including three from the same family, died in a stampede near the Ashok Dham temple in Bihar's Lakhisarai district on Monday, while 25 people were injured, officials said.

Bihar chief minister Samrat Choudhary announced an ex-gratia of ₹4 lakh to the next of kin of the deceased.

Officials said the incident occurred around 6.40 am on the route between Ashok Dham railway station and the temple when a large crowd of devotees gathered for 'Jalabhishek' (offering water to Lord Shiva).

Lakhisarai district magistrate (DM) Shaileendra Kumar told reporters, "The crowd became particularly heavy between 6.20 am and 6.40 am. The queue of devotees had extended towards Ashok Dham station, where two trains were stationed as per schedule. A sudden collapse of an electric pole triggered panic among the devotees. A rumour reportedly spread that the fallen pole was electrically charged, causing people to rush in different directions. The resulting panic led to a stampede, with several devotees falling and being crushed by the crowd."

DM Kumar, however, claimed

A RUMOUR THAT A FALLEN ELECTRIC POLE WAS ELECTRICALLY CHARGED TRIGGERED PANIC AMONG DEVOTEES HEADING FROM THE TEMPLE TO THE RLY STATION, OFFICIALS SAID

the electric pole had an insulated cable and was not a live wire. He said authorities had made arrangements for a large number of devotees, but the crowd was much bigger than expected.

Among the deceased were Hemlata Devi (55), Lalita Devi (50) and Savita Kumari (35), all residents of Haisi locality in Lakhisarai; Mannala Devi (44), a native of Barahiya in Lakhisarai; Rinku Devi (50), a native of Rungta; Saroj Devi (55) of Patna; and Savitri Devi (49), a resident of Lakhisarai.

A probe into the stampede has been ordered by the government and will be conducted by an additional district magistrate (ADM)-rank officer of Lakhisarai, according to divisional commissioner Prem Singh Meena. "All aspects of the inci-

dent, including lapses, if any, by the district administration, will be probed," Meena said.

President Droupadi Murmu and Vice President CP Radhakrishnan expressed grief over the deaths of the devotees in the stampede. President Murmu also prayed for the swift recovery of those injured.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed grief over the loss of lives in the stampede at Lakhisarai. PM Modi prayed for the speedy recovery of the injured and assured that the local administration was assisting those affected.

Devotees flag lapses in crowd management

Eye witnesses and relatives of victims of the Lakhisarai stampede at Ashokdham temple alleged serious lapses in crowd management and security, claiming the local administration and temple management failed to prepare adequately despite expectations of a large gathering on the third Monday of Shravan.

Vinod Kumar, who travelled from Mokama to the temple, said around 100 people were allegedly trying to force their way through the entrance, pushing those in the queue. His wife was caught in the crush. The entrance was on a slope, he said,

and the bamboo barricades broke amid the jostling. "There was no administration, no care," he alleged.

Sanjeev Kumar Singh, a devotee, said "Baricading had been installed around the area to regulate the queue, with devotees passing through to five lines instead of a single line."

Another devotee, Sandhya Kumari, alleged the roughly 25-foot cement pole had been erected in an agricultural field by digging only around two-and-a-half feet into the ground and that its base had not been adequately strengthened. She said the pole first bent and then fell.

Saurabh Jorwal, managing director of the South Bihar Power Distribution Company Limited (SBPDCL), on the other hand, said: "The electric pole had a concrete base. We are trying to ascertain whether the pole fell due to weakening away of the earth around it or due to the pressure exerted by the large number of devotees who accessed the paved pathway leading to the temple along the agricultural field where the electric pole was erected. The electric pole fell around 70 metres from the bamboo barricades put up by the administration leading to the temple. We are trying to ascertain the cause behind the fall of the electric pole."

SC TIGHTENS BAIL FOR FOREIGNERS IN DRUG CASES

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday tightened regime for grant of bail to foreign nationals caught with commercial quantities of drugs by ordering mandatory deposit of passport, two sureties for securing release and departmental proceedings against police, court officials and revenue staff in the event the sureties turn out to be bogus.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Augustine George Masih passed the order while dealing with a bail cancellation plea filed by Centre against a Nigerian national who was found to be an active member of a drug trafficking syndicate and an absconder in connection with details of surety and his local contact furnished by him turned to be fake. Realising the gap in the system, the top court suggested a slew of reforms aimed at expediting proceedings under the NDPS Act against foreign nationals and introducing a stringent bail mechanism for their release on bail. **ABRAHAM THOMAS**

T'gana SIR: 7.3 million deleted in draft rolls

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: As many as 7.3 million names have not been included in Telangana's draft electoral rolls published by the Election Commission of India (ECI) on Monday as part of the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

Another 9.2 million electors will be issued notices over anomalies or failures to establish a link with the 2002 rolls during the ongoing SIR, Telangana chief electoral officer (CEO) C Sudharshan Reddy told reporters. He said that about 7.3 million names were in the absent, shifted, dead or duplicate list.

Genuine electors can still have their names included in the electoral rolls by filing the claims and objections period from August 17 to September 16 by submitting Form 6 along with the prescribed declaration form, the CEO said.

"The enumeration forms of 7,33,92,3 electors, accounting

for 27.0%, could not be collected and updated," Reddy said, adding the revision was aimed at maximising electoral participation, not at indiscriminately deleting names from the rolls.

20.8 MN IN MAHA MAY BE DELETED FROM ELECTORAL ROLLS

MUMBAI: The draft electoral rolls, which will be published on August 24, will likely exclude over 20.8 million or 21.25% electors in the state, as the deadline for the SIR ended on Monday. The Election Commission will furnish the final number of the deleted voters on Tuesday.

According to office of CEO of Maharashtra, until 10 am on Monday, 2,07,93,916 enumeration forms were classified as non-collectible of the total 3,78,54,049 electors. This means many electors were not traceable when BLOs visited their houses on the registered address. The electors were either absent, had moved, were deceased or registered at more than one address.

5 Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday announced a full waiver on cooperative crop loans up to ₹75,000 distributed among the state's farmers.

The additional waiver follows the government's May 25 announcement of a complete waiver on crop loans up to ₹50,000 available by small farmers. The state's minister for agriculture, P. Venu, said the waiver was subject to a waiver of up to ₹75,000, while loans above ₹1 lakh would be subject to a 23% interest waiver.

"It is a nation that respects agriculture and accords proper protection and



C Joseph Vijay

support to farmers can the people live with prosperity and happiness," said the chief minister.

Considering the representations of farmers' associations across the state, a June 19 order was issued to revise the scheme, he said. "Under this, full loan waiver was announced for those who had borrowed up to ₹75,000 for those who had borrowed above ₹75,000, thereby waiving cooperative crop loans to the tune of ₹5,93,22,3 crore to help 14.44 lakh (1.44 million) farmers," he said.

The bank accounts of 1.33 million farmers received a cumulative ₹5,267 crore under this waiver on July 21.

238,264 farmers who have taken crop loans between ₹75,000 and ₹1 lakh will receive a waiver of up to ₹75,000 each. This will enable them to get an additional waiver of up to ₹40,000 over and above the waiver amount already received," said the CM. Although crop loans were waived in the past, amounts payable by the government to cooperative banks were remitted over a gap of 4-5 years, he said.

Farmers association across the state welcomed the announcement. "This announcement will meet the expectations of smaller and marginal farmers. We want the government to announce a full waiver of crop loans to all farmers," a member of Tamil Nadu Vivasayi Sangam, told HT.

Represented by advocates Abhishek Desai, Mohini Redhade, Vijay Singh and Deepesh Ramnani, the petitioner informed the court that the 34-day closure caused a financial loss of ₹8.74 lakh to the business. "Despite the

high-level compliance, the food licence has not been revoked," the lawyer said.

The FDA argued before the court that the food licence had not been revoked by the petitioner. Had it been, the petitioner would have appealed before the FDA. However, the petitioner's food licence suspension was not revoked, prompting it to move the high court.

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Pak-based terror network thwarted before I-Day: Shah

Neeraj Chauhan
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NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Monday announced dismantling an ISI-backed terror network, led by Shahzad Bhatti, with the arrest of over 200 terror suspects and detention of 253 more operatives in a coordinated operation across 14 states just ahead of Independence Day.

Agencies across 14 states registered a total 80 first information reports (FIRs) and recovered improvised explosive devices (IEDs), grenades bearing Pakistan Ordnance Factory markings, pistols, live cartridges and espionage CCTV's — confirming the network's direct cross-border links.

"Modi govt destroyed the ISI-backed terror group Shahzad Bhatti Network ahead of Independence Day and thwarted its plan for using a real-time intelligence-sharing system for arresting more than 200 operatives," Shah said on his X account.

"Indian security forces ripped apart the network by launching coordinated operations across different locations in 14 states, upholding a brilliant example of India's zero-tolerance towards terrorism. Substantial recoveries, including IEDs, grenades bearing Pakistan Ordnance Factory markings, pistols, live cartridges and espionage CCTV's confirm 'the network's direct cross-border links'."

Shahzad Bhatti Network (SBN) is a Pakistan-based, ISI-backed terror syndicate linked to grenades, IEDs and people both inside and outside India. The syndicate has also been paying local conduits to police, defence and religious sites, and to install CCTV cameras for espionage, the ministry of home affairs said in a statement.

Wanted by the National Investigation Agency (NIA), Bhatti emerged as a key figure in several investigations related to terror attacks, organised crimes and online radicalisation efforts of youngsters in India in the past couple of years.



Amit Shah

Maharashtra (8), Uttarakhnad (5), Karnataka, Gujarat and Bihar (3 each), and Telangana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir and Kerala (2 each) — with fresh FIRs registered in Delhi and Karnataka, it said.

Cumulatively, the ministry said, over 80 FIRs and 200+ arrests have been recorded against Shahzad Bhatti Network under unlawful activities prevention Act, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, arms act, NDPS act, and explosives act, among others.

Asserting that Indian government has zero-tolerance for cross border terror, it further said that recoveries, the state-recruited terror cells, IEDs, grenades bearing Pakistan Ordnance Factory markings, pistols, live cartridges and espionage CCTV's confirm "the network's direct cross-border links."

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NEW WEBSITE LETS USERS REPORT BRIBES IN INDIA

NEW DELHI: A new website called "bribes.fyi" has emerged as a platform where users can anonymously report details of bribes they were asked to pay, including the role, amount and department involved. According to the website, it is India's first crowdsourced bribe registry that is completely anonymous and free to use.

The website aggregates the reported data into three sections: reports, departments and cities. It also allows users to compare the number of reported bribes across different departments, providing an overview of the reports submitted through the website. The departments mentioned on the website include the Police, RTI, Revenue/Land Records, Passport Office, Municipal Corporation, GST Office, Election Board, Income Tax, and FDI.

HC fines FDA for suspending licence of Maha shop with 98% compliance

Karuna Nidhi
karuna.nidhi@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Monday directed the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) to pay ₹5 lakh to a sweet shop for keeping its food licence suspended even though the shop was declared 98% hygiene compliant during a recent inspection. The court said the continuation of the license suspension amounted to "torture and harassment."

"This is harassment. They're losing on business. Who will compensate for the loss," a division bench of acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhade asked the FDA officials. "You want us to believe that there's no malice on your

mind," the judges wondered. The court was hearing a petition filed by Gurunank Dargi and Syeda in Pune, which had challenged the FDA's suspension of its food licence on June 12 following a food poisoning complaint.

After the sweet shop submitted a compliance report on July 9, a re-inspection was carried out, and the FDA issued a 98% compliance report on July 13. However, the petitioner's food licence suspension was not revoked, prompting it to move the high court.

Represented by advocates Abhishek Desai, Mohini Redhade, Vijay Singh and Deepesh Ramnani, the petitioner informed the court that the 34-day closure caused a financial loss of ₹8.74 lakh to the business. "Despite the

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Black money in polls: SC orders 1-yr probe deadline, spl courts

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday cracked down on the use of black money and other inducements in elections, directing completion of probes into electoral offences within a year, asking high courts to designate special courts for speedy disposal and making their approval mandatory before prosecution against candidates is withdrawn during a particular election cycle.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and N Kottiaswari Singh also directed authorities seizing cash or other assets suspected to be linked to an electoral offence to report the seizure to the jurisdictional district magistrate, additional district magistrate or competent court within 24 hours, along with written reasons showing a prima facie nexus with the suspected offence.

The directions came while deciding an appeal against a 2015 Karnataka HC order.

The bench said voting was the citizen's one direct opportunity to influence governance and warned that if this choice was tainted by external influences, "the very essence of democracy" was compromised. An electoral choice influenced by such factors, it said, becomes "somebody else's choice being thrust upon them."

The court noted that 3,87,430 FIRs were registered during the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. Of these, 1,66,044 resulted in convictions, 1,06,841 were pending trial, 7,930 remained under investigation and 76,987 closure reports had been filed. The conviction rate was 42.5%.

For assembly elections held between 2019 and 2025, 2,01,894 FIRs were registered. Of these, 40,155 resulted in convictions, 79,148 remained pending trial, 4,665 were under investigation and 53,126 closure reports had been filed.

The bench was concerned about the pendency of election-related prosecutions and their related withdrawal after changes in political dispensations. The Election Commission had told the court that unilateral



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The bench was concerned about the pendency of election-related prosecutions and their related withdrawal after changes in political dispensations. The Election Commission had told the court that unilateral

withdrawal of cases by state governments after a change in government was a "problematic reality".

The court directed that "For withdrawal of cases against candidates in a particular election cycle, the approval of the concerned High Court is mandatory".

It also directed investigating officers to make "every possible endeavour" to complete investigations within one year of FIR registration.

Reasons must be recorded for delays and communicated to the Election Commission, while quarterly status reports must be submitted through a nodal officer. The bench further directed that when Static Surveillance Teams detect cash exceeding ₹10 lakh, the information must be forwarded to the income-tax authorities.

On trials, the court said all efforts must be made for expeditious disposal of cases against candidates and sitting MPs and MLAs, keeping in mind the recurring five-year election cycle. It directed high courts to designate courts, following their respective procedures, for prompt hearing and disposal of such cases.

The court also specifically directed courts dealing with cases arising from the 2024 Lok Sabha elections and assembly elections held between 2019 and 2025 to take them to their logical conclusion "with utmost expedition", noting the large percentage of pending cases.

The Election Commission and respective state governments have been directed to file a compliance report on the implementation of the directions by November 18, 2026.

SELF-ENUMERATION PHASE OF CENSUS IN SNOW-BOUND AREAS COMMENCES

HTC and agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The self-enumeration process, as part of the house-to-house population enumeration under Phase-II of Census 2027, began on Monday in the Union Territory (UT) of Ladakh and snow-bound non-synchronous areas of Jammu & Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand. The exercise will continue until August 31.

Lieutenant Governor V K Saxena launched the process in Leh by completing his enumeration. "This process is not merely statistical; it is a national endeavour that would lay the foundation for informed governance, equitable resource distribution, and inclusive development," he said. In Uttarakhand, the exercise will cover around 52,000 people across 131 villages and three towns in four districts. "Compared to other hill states, Uttarakhand has a relatively small snow-bound area," said state director of Census Operations Eva Srivastava.

48-hour shutdown in Manipur amid protests

Meanwhile, student-led anti-Census protests continued in Manipur, with the Campaign for Just and Fair Delimitation (JFD) announcing a 48-hour shutdown on Monday.

Two students were injured during security forces' action against protesters on Monday. Police said the protesters attempted to intervene in a Census training session in Imphal, where tension escalated when security forces tried to control the mob. Demonstrators demanded postponement of the Census until implementation of the NRC and resettlement of internally displaced persons.

BJP rejig blends RSS roots, fresh faces

Smriti Kak Ramachandran

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party's new organisational team signals an attempt to balance ideological continuity with generational change, while preparing for a string of assembly elections and seeking to reset its political and social narrative.

The party has retained B.L. Santhosh as national general secretary (Organisation), along with Shivprakash and Saudan Singh as national joint general secretaries (Organisation), while bringing back Ram Madhav, one of the most recognisable faces of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), into its leadership fold.

Santhosh Poonia, another leader with strong Sangh ties, has also been brought into the national team. Poonia was in charge of the Haryana assembly elections in 2024, when the BJP overcame strong anti-incumbency to win a third consecutive term. "There are many other names on the list who have cut their teeth in RSS and its affiliate the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) such as Vinod Tawde, VD Sharma, Biplob Deb and Swadesh Singh — these appointments should put to rest any speculation that the Sangh and the party are not on the same page," said a senior party leader.

But the larger message, according to multiple leaders who spoke to HT, is an attempt to reset the party's narrative and connect with younger voters.

"The protests against paper leaks had a wide resonance on the ground. The government took several steps to address the concerns and plug the leaks, but the narrative, particularly on social media, was against the government and the party," said the leader.

The focus on the upcoming

assembly elections, particularly Uttar Pradesh, is also evident in the revamp of the BJP's IT cell. Amit Malviya, who frequently courted controversy over his social media posts, has been replaced by Deepak Mhaskey. "A fresh set of people will assist the new IT cell head Deepak Mhaskey," the leader said, adding that the change signalled an attempt by the party to revisit its social media strategy.

The new team also reflects a greater emphasis on organisational experience, a second party leader said. "A lot of people who have previously worked in state units and in various capacities in morchas have been picked. These are people who have age on their side, administrative and organisational experience, and also represent social diversity," said the second leader, citing Ashish Agarwal, co-convenor of the media cell, and national secretaries Manoj Tigga and Bhola Singh.

The party has also sought to balance younger faces with leaders carrying institutional experience. Former chief ministers Vasundhara Raje, Tirath Singh Rawat and Biplob Deb, along with senior leaders such as Tawde and Bansal, provide that continuity.

"Whenever a new team is announced, balance is key. While the party president Nitin Gadgil is the youngest president that we have, it was imperative to have experienced hands on board as well, who have institutional memory and insight of how senior leaders worked," the first leader said.

The appointments also underline the party's emphasis on professional diversity as well, there are professors, doctors, PhDs, Chartered Accountants and lawyers."

C'garh leader Mhaskey named new IT cell chief

PTI and Smriti Kak Ramachandran

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NEW DELHI: The BJP's new social media convener, Deepak Mhaskey, 58, is currently chairman of the Chhattisgarh Medical Services Corporation Ltd and has served as a state BJP spokesperson in the past.

A former chemistry professor, Mhaskey, who replaced Amit Malviya in the post, has led social media campaigns during the West Bengal elections polls and in Bihar, a party functionary said. He has a strong insight into how the social media narrative, as well as algorithms and trends, work, this functionary said. He has also served as an independent director on the board of public sector company Engineers India Ltd. Describing his appointment as a major responsibility, Mhaskey said an ordinary party worker like him has been entrusted with such an important role. "Those who misuse social media and create confusion by spreading misinformation will be countered by our team by ensuring that the correct information reaches people," he told reporters in Rajpur. "Our target is to ensure BJP's victory (in polls). State and national teams will work together towards this goal."

Mhaskey has his work cut out because the party is looking at a transformed social media landscape, the functionary quoted above said. The PM (Narendra Modi) himself has led by example. He has adapted to platforms that are more popular with Gen Z and Gen Alpha. At a meeting with Rajya Sabha MPs earlier this month he told them to ensure dig-

Heads of key units

Yuva Morcha Dr Hemang Joshi
Mahila Morcha Roop Kumari Choudhary
OBG Morcha Anshul Maurya
Kisan Morcha Bansal Gurjar
SC Morcha Shresh Kumar Ram (Bihar)
ST Morcha Mannal Rawat
Minority Morcha Kunwar Basit Ali (UP)
North-East Cell Sambit Patra

nity during interactions on social media and actively engage on as many platforms as they can."

The party has been keeping track of how some leaders, including lawmakers, use social media platforms. Recently elected Rajya Sabha MPs, during a meeting, were presented with a SWOT analysis of their social media profiles, the BJP functionary said.

There was, however, some criticism on social media about the choice of the co-convenors. Several handles put out screenshots of old posts from Priti Gandhi and Alok Bhatt in improper language, some of which are even deleted.

Former TMC MP Saket Gokhale posted on X: "All the new BJP IT cell co-heads have 'protected' & hidden their timelines. Probably busy deleting all the filthy & misogynist posts they've made earlier. The new IT cell head, meanwhile, has deleted ALL his past tweets. Being abusive is a primary qualification for BJP IT cell."

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Transgender IDs to be valid till verdict is out on new law: Govt

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NEW DELHI: The Union government on Monday told the Supreme Court that transgender identity card holders under a previous regime enacted by the 2019 law will continue to be treated as valid and retain the benefits attached to their cards until the top court decides the constitutional validity of the new law.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, told a bench, comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, that the government would file its detailed response within four weeks, while assuring that existing transgender (TG) cards would continue to operate in the meantime.

The bench recorded the assurance and ordered that "TG cards will continue to operate subject to the outcome of the petitions".

The court, however, declined to extend the interim protection to those who are still in the process of obtaining transgender cards or whose cards have been cancelled, saying it could not pass a blanket order while examining the validity of the amended law.

The bench recalled that its immediate concern was to ensure that persons who had already obtained transgender cards did not lose benefits they had acquired under the earlier legal framework.

The concern expressed by us last time was that those who have received cards, they should continue to have the benefits," said the bench.

Senior advocate Arundhati Katju pointed out some transgender persons had not yet obtained cards but were already in the process of transitioning. Senior advocate Anand Grover, Rajiv Shukthar, Jayna Kothari and an array of other counsel also appeared in the matter.

Another counsel told the bench that some transgender cards were also cancelled.

The bench responded that cases involving cancelled cards would involve a separate deci-



The court declined interim protection to under-process and cancelled ID cards.

sion-making process and could not be covered by a blanket direction. "Where cards have been cancelled, there is also a decision-making process involved. We cannot pass a blanket order," it said.

The court also made it clear that it was conscious of the need to avoid passing an interim order that could prejudice the constitutional challenge to the new legislation.

"We are examining the law. We can't issue an interim order that could comment on the merit of the case," said the bench, while protecting those who already possessed transgender cards. Another counsel sought a direction that pending applications for transgender cards be processed.

The bench noted that it had been indicated earlier that existing transgender cards will be preserved, but said submissions that identity documents had been changed even without transgender cards would require consideration. "Some submissions are coming from the Bar that without a transgender card, identity documents have been changed. This has to be considered," it told Mehta.

The proceedings are part of the Supreme Court's examination of a batch of petitions challenging the constitutional validity of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026.

The new law has been challenged on the ground that it dilutes the principle of self-identification of gender recognised by the Supreme Court in its landmark 2014 NALSA judgment.

SC asks if liability cap under SHANTI act operates against courts

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Centre to clarify if the cap on compensation in case of a nuclear tragedy under the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Act 2025 will prevent constitutional courts from fixing higher amounts as part of "fair and just" compensation.

Issuing notice on a petition filed by a group of public spirited persons challenging the validity of the SHANTI Act for capping liability of operators and nuclear suppliers, a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant made it clear that the response is sought only on two issues - whether the cap on compensation operates against constitutional courts and allegations of conflict of interest in making appointments to the Atomic

CONSTITUTIONAL COURTS WILL BE AT LIBERTY TO ASSESS COMPENSATION AS SUCH A POWER IS INDEPENDENT OF THE ACT, THE TOP COURT OBSERVED

Energy Regulatory Board (AERB).
"We issue notice to the Centre

to clarify that irrespective of the provisions of the Act, nothing will deter constitutional courts from providing fair and just compensation," said the bench, also comprising justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana.

The court was hearing a public interest litigation filed by retired bureaucrat EAS Sarma and others which claimed that the decision to cap liability of private players in the event of a nuclear tragedy will encourage project

proponents to cut corners on safety thereby endangering human lives.

The petition raised serious concerns over the provisions of the SHANTI Act capping a private operator's liability as low as ₹100 crores and even the government's liability to share the residual burden of liability to the extent of USD 300 million (approximately ₹3,000 crore).

The court was of the prima facie view that despite the cap

under the Act, constitutional courts will be at liberty to assess compensation as such a power is independent of the Act. It even told the petitioners, "Why do you have this apprehension? The Parliament has fixed liability of project proponents which is a step to incentivise them. The Central government also owes liability under the Act. Where is the restraint on constitutional courts from granting compensation."

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{ TWISHA SHARMA CASE }

CBI charge sheet names ex-judge, son

Shruti Tomar

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BHOPAL: Former actor-model Twisha Sharma died by suicide in May this year after facing sustained mental torture by her husband Samarth Singh and mother-in-law Giribala Singh, a former district judge, according to a charge sheet filed by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

Twisha, 33, was found dead under suspicious circumstances at her marital home in Bhopal on May 12, just five months after her marriage to Samarth, who is also a lawyer. In the FIR, it was alleged that Samarth had taken her to AIIMS Bhopal, where he claimed that she hanged herself at home at 10.20 pm. The doctors at AIIMS informed the police that she was brought in dead to the hospital.

In its nearly 600-page charge sheet filed before a special court in Bhopal on August 14, CBI has accused Samarth and Giribala Singh of "sustained psychological harm" on Twisha and charged



Twisha Sharma

them with abetment to suicide. The agency has kept the probe open into claims of dowry demands and dowry death.

"During investigation it has been established that accused Giribala and Samarth Singh have committed offences punishable under sections 85 (cruelty and harassment caused by husband and his family members), 108 (abetment of suicide), and 305 (common intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, in connection with the death of Twisha Sharma," the charge sheet said.

Twisha, a former Miss Pune, talked to her sister-in-law, mother and father and informed that Samarth had become very aggressive

and violent towards her, it said, adding the accused discovered her hanging from a gym belt at around 10.23 pm on May 12.

According to the charge sheet, at 9.20 pm, shortly before her death, Twisha messaged her sister-in-law, saying "Ask him (Samarth Singh) to collect left over of his wife. But tomorrow. Let me die in peace right now."

After the initial police probe and a second autopsy ordered by the Madhya Pradesh high court to clear doubts and address the family's allegations of lapses in the first autopsy performed by AIIMS Bhopal, CBI took over the probe and arrested Samarth and Giribala.

The second autopsy, conducted by a four-member team from AIIMS Delhi, confirmed ante-mortem hanging as the cause of death.

"The cause of death is asphyxia as a result of ante-mortem hanging which is suicidal in manner produced by the examined ligature material, the gymnastic belt with a ring," the charge sheet said. Forensic psychological assess-

ment of diaries, chats, and CCTV footage indicated Twisha faced "hopelessness, sustained psychological harm and absence of support", according to the charge sheet. The charge sheet recorded her statements mentioned in various chats about "character assassination", questioning the foetus's paternity after abortion, and pressure to transfer ₹20 lakh from her mutual funds to a joint account for investment in Chinese markets.

It said that on May 9, Twisha told her sister-in-law Rashmi Abrol: "He (Samarth Singh) has crossed all the limits and he asked her whether it was his child or someone else's, is that why I aborted it. I am feeling suffocated. I swear I will be able to find courage to finish myself completely... I will find a way to vanish."

CBI has sent Twisha's iPhone and DVR data to CFSI, DFSS New Delhi for forensic examination. "The extraction may reveal incriminating material pertaining to the case against the accused..." the charge sheet said.

DIMAGI NAXAL PARTY HANDLE FACES TEMPORARY INSTA CURBS

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NEW DELHI: The Instagram handle of the newly formed Dimagi Naxal Party (DNP) was restricted in India on Monday before becoming accessible again after being unavailable for about two hours in the morning, its creators claimed.

Created on August 15 after PM Modi used the term "dimagi Naxals" in his Independence Day speech, the account said two posts were removed on August 16 and 17 under legal requirements. The DNP's followers rose from 204,000 at 2 pm to 272,000 by 10 pm. It alleged its handle could not be found through Instagram search, describing the restriction as a "shadow ban". On X, it wrote, "We are EDUCATED, We Use Brain."

The party has now changed their handle on Instagram from dimaginaxalparty to dimaginaxalparty_india.

Skymet raises drought risk, cuts monsoon forecast to 85% of LPA

Jasjeet Gandhok and Pallavi Singhal

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NEW DELHI: Private weather forecaster Skymet Weather on Monday issued a revised forecast for the southwest monsoon, stating it now expects monsoon rainfall to be 85% of the long period average (LPA), with a 70% probability of drought. In its initial forecast issued in April, Skymet had forecast the monsoon to be 94% of the LPA, flagging a worsening trend, aided by a strengthening El Nino.

"Skymet foresees a 70% chance of drought and expects the seasonal rainfall to be 85% of the Long Period Average (LPA)," it said in a statement on Monday.

"Skymet predicts that August may end with a monthly shortfall of 16% rainfall of LPA. Growing El Nino and weak Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) will cast a shadow, and the month of Sep-

tember is likely to be rain-deficit by 20% of LPA," it added. To be sure, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) in its April forecast had said the monsoon rainfall was likely to be 92% of LPA this year. However, in its June outlook, IMD revised this forecast downward — to 90% — and attached a 60% probability to a deficient season, meaning there is a better-than-even chance that total rainfall falls below the threshold that even qualifies as below-normal.

IMD has not shared a revised forecast for the overall monsoon season since. "Another update will be issued by the end of August," a senior IMD official said. As of August 17, the all India rainfall was 13% below LPA. August has largely seen the monsoon deficit stay static, between 11-13%. This deficit stood at -13% as of July 31 — an improvement from the -40% India saw at the end of June. Between June 1 and August 17, India has received 518.7mm, down from the 596.2mm it should have received normally during this period.

Forecasts by IMD show the monsoon is already weakening in the second half of the month, with the trough shifting to the foothills. Skymet Managing Director

Jatin Singh said, "Strong coupling of the atmospheric and oceanic circulation across the equatorial Pacific Ocean is raising the probability of a powerful El Nino. It is likely to make a transition from the 'strong' to 'very strong' category during early September," he said.

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BJP TEAM REJIG

Deepak Misra, who has been appointed as convenor.

There is speculation that some of those replaced could find a place in the Cabinet during a reshuffle or be deputed to various states and territories. A person familiar with the matter said a reshuffle could come in September.

Overall, the list of 65 office-bearers includes 12 women. Among the states, there are 10 names from Delhi and many states such as Assam and Nagaland have a single entry.

"Congratulations to the newly appointed national office-bearers of the BJP and those who have been given various responsibilities in the party. This newly appointed team brings together organisational experience, energy and grassroots connect. I am confident they will give their best in strengthening our party and focussing on public service. My best wishes to them," Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on X.

The organisational rejig was widely anticipated because it is seen as a key step leading to the much-awaited cabinet reshuffle, the first in the third term of the National Democratic Alliance. The new team adheres to the BJP's social engineering model, which gives representation to various castes and tribes, and is a mix of experienced and fresh faces.

Among the 13 vice-presidents, the party retained former Rajasthan CM Visvanath Raju Scindia from Rajasthan, lawmaker Bidda Verma from Uttar Pradesh, and lawmaker Baijant Jay Panda from Odisha. The new inclusions were Tirath Singh Rawat from Uttarakhand; Ram Madhav from Delhi; D Purandeshwari from Andhra Pradesh, a former national general secretary and state unit president; former MJA Varshaben Narendrabhai Doshi from Gujarat; former Union minister Bharti Pravin Pawar from Maharashtra; former Punjab minister Manpreet Singh Badal; and former SC cell chief Lal Singh Arya from Madhya Pradesh. M Nagaria, an OBC leader from Karnataka and a Rajya Sabha MP, Tariq Mansoor, a Pasmanda Muslim and former vice-chancellor of Aligarh Muslim University; and Madhuchandra Kar, a Bengal doctor, were also in the list.

Among the eight national general secretaries, the party retained only Vinod Tawde and Sunil Bansal. The list includes Harish Dwivedi, a former MP

from Basti in Uttar Pradesh was recently the state in-charge for Assam and is Brahmachari; former Rajasthan state president and other backward classes (OBC) leader Satish Poonia; Madhya Pradesh tribal leader Jagendra Patel; and Haryana Rajya Sabha member Sanjay Bhatia. Bhatia did not contest the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, vacating his Kanpur seat for former Haryana CM Manohar Lal Khattar.

Poonia is the old Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh member and perceived to be at loggerheads with Raju. The party has not given an SC representation in this category, opting for a ST name.

Tawde and Bansal, who both played key roles as election in-charges in several state polls, were retained keeping in view the upcoming assembly elections. While Bansal played a key role in West Bengal, Tawde was in-charge of Kerala and state in-charge of Bihar, overseeing the transition from Nitish Kumar stepping down as CM to Sarit Choudhary taking over as CM this year.

The party also rewarded turncoats: former Aam Aadmi Party MP Sandeep Pathak and Rohan Gupta, who switched sides from the Congress, were made national secretaries; Manpreet Badal, who was earlier with the Shiromani Akali Dal, was named vice-president.

The 16 national secretaries were drawn from various states and largely comprised younger people. This included 3-term MP Bholu Singh from Bulandshahr; Rajya Sabha MP from Madhya Pradesh and OBC leader Kavita Patidar; and former Kerala unit chief K Surendran. Anil Antony, a minority face from Kerala, was retained. The list also included Phangnon Konyak, the first woman from Nagaland in the Rajya Sabha; author and academic Swadesh Singh, who was part of the election team in Bengal; Mriganka Deo Barman from the indigenous Koch Rajbongshi community of Assam; and Manoj Tigga, a tribal leader who was also the chief whip in the Bengal assembly.

Notable leaders dropped included Arun Singh, who was party general secretary since 2015, making him one of the longest-serving functionaries; Radha Mohan Das Agrawal, who was general secretary in 2023, a year after he vacated his long-held Gorakhpur assembly seat for CM Yogi Adityanath. Agrawal

and Singh are both Rajya Sabha MPs. Taran Chugh — who was recently elected to the Rajya Sabha — was made office in-charge, replacing Arun Singh. Dushyant Gautam, a Dalit leader who unsuccessfully contested the Delhi assembly polls in 2025 and was general secretary since September 2020, was also dropped. His name was associated with the Ankit Bhandari murder case in Uttarakhand in 2022. Gautam filed a defamation lawsuit against the political parties and individuals involved and the Delhi high court passed interim orders to remove all social media posts linking him to the murder case.

Malviya was replaced by Misra, who served as the state in-charge of the BJP IT cell Chhatgishgar and a state spokesperson. He has four co-convenors: Shivnandan Dwivedi, who co-authored a book on home minister Amit Shah; Priti Gandhi, Alok Bhatt; and Arun Yadav.

The appointment of former Madhya Pradesh state unit president, VD Sharma, as the in-charge of various cells is an indication that the party will revive these cells or prokash it as they were known for wider outreach.

Rajesh Mangal from Rajasthan was the co-treasurer, while Rajya Sabha member Ashish Aggarwal, Siddharth Yadav, and Pradeep Bhandari will be co-convenors of the media cell.

Nabin — a five-term legislator from Bihar and now a Rajya Sabha MP — was appointed national president on January 20. His appointment was perceived to mark the beginning of a generational shift in the party that formed a month before Nabin was born in May 1980.

NE DRUG SHIPMENTS

of both the scale of the malaise and the extent of the crackdown.

"Every heroin shipment from Myanmar is smuggled in plastic soap cases. There are different sizes of such cases that can fit 50,000, 200 grams of heroin. In Myanmar, this has been the trend for several years. With insurgency almost over in northeastern states, the government's focus is on drugs, so, naturally we are making recoveries every day. The most common drug (smuggled) from Myanmar is heroin. The soap cases are hidden below vegetables, and with random household items and transported by road," said an Assam police officer, who asked not to be named.

Interrogations of captured drug smugglers and users have shed light on the ubiquity of the soap cases, according to officials from Mizoram's narcotics department.

"The Myanmar smugglers believe soap cases help preserve the form of the heroin because the packet is sealed and protected from moisture when wrapped in polythene," joint PZohmtinglang, a joint commissioner (enforcement) of Mizoram's Narcotics department.

"We have also been told that it is easier to sell the product without having to weigh it because of the different sizes (in which the cases are available). It works for users as well as smugglers. The heroin is sold on the basis of the size of the soap case," he added.

Narcotics Control Bureau's (NCB) 2025 annual report said Myanmar has overtaken Afghanistan as the world's largest illicit opium producer following the Taliban's 2022 poppy ban, increasing trafficking risks for India's northeastern states. Myanmar's illicit opium cultivation rose about 56% from 30,200 hectares in 2021 to 47,000 hectares in 2023, making it a key substitute source for the global supply gap left by Afghanistan.

The NCB identified India's eastern borders as the "most direct and porous entry point," with Manipur, Mizoram and Nagaland facing the greatest exposure. Civil society organisations too have been mobilised to help in this fight.

Mawswiliana, general secretary of the Central Young Mizo Association (YMA), Mizoram's most influential civil society organisation, said the YMA has declared 2025 and 2027 as "Years of the Fight Against Drugs" and is working with the Union and state governments to combat trafficking.

"Seizures by YMA indicate a high influx of heroin packed in soap cases. They believe the packaging protects the drug from moisture and dirt and makes it easier to measure and sell by weight," he explained. YMA has formed anti-drug squads across the state and involved churches in counselling users, he said.

Last month, home minister Shah also announced a three-year plan for a targeted crackdown on drugs. The Centre's different agencies — DRI, BSF, CRPF, Assam Rifles, NCB — have joined the war on drugs in the Northeast. And all fruits, inside special cavities or with random household items and transported by road," said an Assam police officer, who asked not to be named.

On April 23, an NCB team, along with Assam Rifles, seized 5.45kg of heroin concealed in 474

soap cases in Churachandpur. On July 29, also in Churachandpur, DRI seized 2.7kg of heroin concealed inside 220 soap cases. The CRPF, too, has made similar recoveries. On July 1, it seized nearly 2kg of heroin packed in 168 soap cases in Manipur's Pongpat area.

Amid the intensified crackdown, the Centre in April also approved new NCB zonal offices in Aizawl (Mizoram), Dimapur (Nagaland), and Shillong (Meghalaya). Their primary task — to stop the flow of drugs from the so-called Golden Triangle, comprising Myanmar, Laos and Thailand.

NCB's annual report identified Mizoram's Champhai along the Indo-Myanmar border as a major trafficking corridor. "Champhai shares an unfenced and porous border with Myanmar's Chin state, from where heroin is smuggled and routed through Aizawl to Silchar and then onward through road networks towards Guwahati, Meghalaya and other parts of mainland India," the report said.

For teams on the ground, however, the fight does not end with just the seizure.

An inspector from a Champhai police in Mizoram, who asked not to be named, said the recovery of the soap cases marks the beginning of a tedious legal and administrative process that can continue for months until both the heroin and the cases are eventually destroyed after obtaining the necessary legal orders.

"First, we have to remove the heroin from all the cases in front of a magistrate. Samples of the heroin and the plastic cases are then sent for examination. All the others, sometimes hundreds of soap cases, have to be numbered and kept safely as case property," the officer said.

The scale of the problem was the most visible in April when the Champhai police destroyed drugs worth ₹450 crore seized in various operations. Around 2,000-2,500 seized plastic soap cases were also destroyed along with the drugs.

WIDER DRUG TESTING

existing Civil Aviation Requirements (CAR) on testing for psychoactive substances, with a possible increase in random testing and stronger penalties under the revised framework, "a person in the know of the development said.

The existing CAR, issued in 2021 and effective from January 2022, requires scheduled commercial airlines, air traffic controllers, flight training organisations

(FTOs) and air navigation service providers to conduct random drug tests covering at least 10% of employees in the course of a year.

According to the European Union Aviation Safety Agency (EASA) guidelines, airlines should test personnel for psychoactive substances upon employment and, where there is due cause, following reasonable suspicion assessed by trained personnel or after a serious incident or accident, where testing is possible at the location. Operators may also conduct random testing in line with national requirements to ensure substance misuse does not go undetected and threaten flight safety. The rules cover personnel directly employed by the operator, while contractors are generally excluded unless they are flight or cabin crew.

According to CAR, if a person fails a test, the rules currently ask for them to be removed from flying till the results of confirmatory tests are out.

"After confirmation," the employee is referred for re-addiction rehabilitation and can return to active duty only after a subsequent negative test and fitness certification. If the person is positive for a second time, their licence shall be suspended for three years. A third positive occasion leads to the cancellation of the licence," according to the current CAR.

Speaking on condition of anonymity, an airline official said that mandatory testing of all pilots could affect operational efficiency and on-time performance. "If the drug tests are mandated for all the pilots for airlines, it will be a tough job to do and may lead to an impact in an airline's OTP (on-time performance)," the official said.

On August 13, an IndiGo spokesperson said it "proactively goes far beyond" the 10% testing requirement, with all new flight crew tested and existing crew tested randomly. "Details of all tests conducted are shared with the regulator as mandated. In addition, our cabin crew, engineering and ground staff are also subjected to such testing," the official said.

DELHI S.I.R

stages likely in Delhi at the draft stage are not very different from deletions in other metro cities at this point in the controversial exercise. Chennai and Kolkata saw 35.0% and 25.1% deletions at the draft stage respectively. Ben-

galuru (the rural and urban district taken together) is set to record around 37% deletions, according to data from the Karnataka CEO as of August 16.

According to CEO data, from all 70 assembly constituencies showed that 123,470 of Rohini's 150,398 electors, or 83.43%, had their forms digitised. According to data shared by the chief electoral officer's office, Outer North district had the largest proportion of its forms digitised (75.68%) as of 8pm on August 17.

West district followed with 73.29%, south-west with 73.16%. North-east and north-west also recorded relatively high digitisation rates of 70.94% and 70.89%, respectively.

South-east recorded the lowest digitisation rate among Delhi's 13 districts, with only 56.32% of its 155 million enumeration forms digitised. New Delhi followed at 60.76%, while south and central recorded 61.32% and 61.96%, respectively. Overall, 9.74 million of the 14.5 million enumeration forms had been digitised, taking the city's cumulative digitisation rate to 67.18% by 8pm on August 17.

Tughlakabad had digitised 100,323 forms, out of 192,419 electors, or just 52.14%. That means nearly one in every two electors in Tughlakabad faces the risk of deletion from the electoral roll.

Only two constituencies have crossed 80% digitisation: Rohini in north-west district at 83.43% and Shakti Basti in central north at 83.26%. The next three are Rajouri Garden in the west (79.13%), Mangol Puri in the northwest (78.76%) and Uttam Nagar in the west (77.79%), official data showed.

At the bottom, Tughlakabad (south-east) is followed by Okhla (south-east) at 54.66%, RK Puram (south) at 55.32%, Kirti Nagar (south-east) at 55.94% and Kalkaji (south-east) at 57.18% digitisation. Kalkaji, the constituency of former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, has 181,350 electors, while forms have only been digitised for 103,688 (57.18%).

In Shalimar Bagh, the constituency of chief minister Rekha Gupta, forms have been digitised for 69.14% of the 177,429 electors. In the New Delhi seat, held by public works department minister Parvati Verma, forms have been digitised for 58.24% of 89,683 electors.

The digitisation percentage for Jangpura is 58.45% of 145,823 electors. Greater Kailash fares

slightly better with a digitisation figure of 64.96% of 177,885 electors. The strongest performers are concentrated largely in north and west Delhi. Apart from Rohini and Shakur Basti, Mangol Puri, Rajouri Garden and Uttam Nagar occupy the top five. Bawana, Narela and Mundla — constituencies with significant peripheral and semi-rural areas — also show relatively high digitisation, at 78.29%, 76.21% and 74.52%, respectively. Matiala, another large peripheral constituency, stood at 75.57%, while Najafgarh was at 74.19%.

Among the seven constituencies generally identified as having particularly large Muslim populations — Seemapur, Matia Mahal, Bahapur, Mustafabad, Ballimaran, Chandra Chowk and Okhla — the average digitisation rate was about 68.6%, marginally higher than the city average.

But there was a 22-percentage-point spread within this group. Seemapur stood at 76.63%, with 143,038 of 193,194 forms digitised. Matia Mahal followed at 75.50%, Bahapur at 73% and Mustafabad at 71.91%.

Ballimaran was at 67.35%, Chandra Chowk at 61.02%, and Okhla at just 54.67%. Okhla had 362,813 electors, making it one of the largest constituencies in the Capital, but only 198,297 forms were digitised.

The figures do not support the idea that minority-heavy constituencies uniformly showed lower digitisation. But the performance of Okhla, Ballimaran and Chandra Chowk showed that several such constituencies were substantially behind the city's leading seats for digitisation.

The size of the electorate also did not offer a neat explanation. Matiala had the largest electorate in the dataset, with 438,702 voters, and 75,878 digitisation. Vikaspuri, with 421,792 electors, stood at 65.21%, and Barari, with 428,480 voters, digitised 60.49%.

Kalkaji, the constituency of former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, has 181,350 electors, while forms have only been digitised for 103,688 (57.18%).

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The digitisation percentage for Jangpura is 58.45% of 145,823 electors. Greater Kailash fares

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{ OUR TAKE }

New levers in the BJP machinery

The new appointments to party posts show that the party could be forging new strategies to surmount the challenges it currently faces

To dominate a country as culturally and linguistically diverse and geographically massive as India, a political party needs to have a robust organisation. Key cogs in this structure might not always get the media limelight that ministers and lawmakers do, but they are often no less powerful and consequential, wielding enormous powers to decide the party's strategy, issues, manifestoes, candidates, and funds. Over the past decade, even as the BJP faced some electoral setbacks, it rarely floundered on organisation — swapping chief ministers with ease when other parties made a mess, tightly controlling Rajya Sabha polling when the Opposition routinely failed to tamp down on dissidence, and enforced intra-party discipline with an iron hand.

This is one of the two reasons why the long-pending announcement of the BJP's new organisational structure — roughly seven months after party chief Nitin Nambhok — is important. The new team sees the return of Union minister Piyush Goyal as national treasurer, and by turning to an experienced and senior hand, the party may be strengthening what it sees as a relative weakness. The team also comprises people making a significant comeback — Ram Madhav and Tirath Singh Rawat as vice-presidents, and Smriti Irani as general secretary key among them — alongside an influx of younger women leaders. Six of the 13 vice-presidents are women, helping the BJP make the case that it is following the spirit of women's reservation in its internal appointments and increasing the pressure on other parties to follow suit. Some party wings — such as those for women or young people — have new chiefs, as does the party's IT cell, which was criticised by many as being out of step with young people during the recent student protests. By bringing back some heavyweight leaders, retaining key figures, and inducting a host of young faces — including rewarding turncoats such as Sandip Pathak — the party is attempting continuity while reflecting its expanded geographical reach by giving representation to regions such as West Bengal and the Northeast.

The other reason is that this announcement is a pivotal step leading to the long-awaited Cabinet reshuffle. PM Narendra Modi is usually reticent with ministerial changes, preferring big-bang reshuffles over incremental tweaks. Since the NDA government took office for the third time in 2024, the BJP has won landmark electoral battles and decimated the Opposition but also faced improbable resistance from unorganised young people and simmering discontent over jobs and education. As a party with multiple feedback channels, the BJP must be forging a new strategy to surmount these new challenges. Monday's announcements give a glimpse of this new plan, and suggest possible openings and changes. The whole picture will likely be unveiled by a refreshed Cabinet.

White Paper, whitewashed

When the TVK won a surprise victory in Tamil Nadu earlier this year, it was attributed to a yearning for a change from the established pattern of politics. One of the first things the TVK government did was issue a White Paper on the state's fiscal situation. Despite being one of India's most developed states, Tamil Nadu's finances are far from enviable, especially when it comes to its own tax revenue mobilisation and debt. White Papers, however, cannot restore fiscal health on their own. While they are often a useful tool to berate political predecessors in government for the state of the exchequer, the future of the fisc is determined by the government's current actions. It is in this context that the TVK government's conditional farm loan waiver is disappointing, signalling more than its actual impact. The waiver, announced on the 100th day of the TVK government, is limited to cooperative bank loans and will cost just about ₹1,000 crore to the government. Coming in the middle of an ongoing dispute with Karnataka over sharing of Cauvery water because of low rainfall this year, this might be the government's olive branch to the state's farmers who are angry about water shortfall. Pragmatically, it makes sense. But pragmatism often settles into status-quoism, creating drag on factors like the state of government finances. When a political debutant succumbs to such tactics, it indicates a lack of political imagination and conviction over heralding a new political economy deal. This is where Tamil Nadu's farm loan waiver is disappointing, despite its small fiscal impact or the relief it will bring to farmers.

After Chandrasekaran, the true test for the Tatas

The group needs to build an institutional model where ownership can exercise stewardship, management can exercise authority, and both can coexist without ambiguity

When news broke that N Chandrasekaran would not seek reappointment as chairman of Tata Sons beyond the end of his current term, the reaction was immediate. Tata stocks came under pressure, with TCS falling nearly 4% and pulling the broader Nifty down. Tata is not merely another business group. Its fortunes matter to the Indian stock market and, more broadly, to perceptions about corporate India.

With 26 listed companies and a combined market capitalisation of ₹24.4 lakh crore in March 2026, the Tatas are one of the most significant components of India's equity market. In many ways, the Tata group is India's closest equivalent to a home-grown global corporation. And there are two reasons why Chandrasekaran's decision deserves to be viewed as more than a leadership change. It is a test of whether Tata's governance architecture has kept pace with the institution it has become.

For much of the group's history, the chairman of Tata Sons (the holding company) and the person heading the Tata Trusts (the dominant shareholder) were the same person. JRD

Tata led both for over 50 years. Ratan Tata was the last to straddle both worlds, though he stepped down from Tata Sons in 2012 while continuing to lead the Trusts.

The separation became particularly visible when Cyrus Mistry became chairman of Tata Sons in 2012 while Ratan Tata remained chairman of the Trusts. Their relationship ultimately broke down, culminating in Mistry's removal in 2016. The lesson should have been obvious: Separating ownership and management is sound governance, but it creates the need for an equally strong mechanism to manage differences between the two.

The Tatas took an important institutional step in 2012 by amending Article 118 of Tata Sons' Articles of Association. The amendment effectively prevents the chairman of either the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust or the Sir Ratan Tata Trust from simultaneously becoming chairman of Tata Sons. That was a welcome move. It formally separated trusteeship from business leadership, but institutions are ultimately tested by how people operate within them.

Since Noel Tata became chairman of Tata Trusts after Ratan Tata's death in 2013, the group has been held by different individuals. Differences in perspective are inevitable. The real test is whether the governance framework can accommodate those differences without creating uncertainty at the top.

The second problem is the sheer width of the Tata Sons chairman's responsibilities. The Tata Group comprises 31 companies, operates in more

than 100 countries and collectively employs over a million people. Its businesses range from TCS and Tata Motors to Tata Steel, Titan, Tata Consumer, Air India and its emerging semiconductor and electronics businesses. Formally, each Tata company has its own board and management. In reality, the Tata Sons chairman is inevitably held responsible for the performance and reputation of the entire group. That is an extraordinarily demanding job for one individual.

Chandrasekaran deserves credit for what he achieved. Since he took over in 2017, the combined market value of Tata companies has more than tripled from about ₹8.4 lakh crore to more than ₹27 lakh crore. He also pushed the group into ambitious new areas, including semiconductors, electronics, and a major rebuilding of the aviation business. The challenge for his successor will be to manage a much larger, more complex, and more capital-intensive Tata Group while deciding where the group should deploy capital.

Tata has historically enjoyed something few companies have — a governance premium. Customers trusted Tata. Employees trusted Tata. Investors trusted Tata. But it cannot be taken for granted. Tata has been tested by some of the world's most demanding business partners regarded the name as an assurance of institutional integrity. That premium remains considerable. But it cannot be taken for granted.

The Mistry episode, the continuing debate over the relationship between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons, questions around the future structure of Tata Sons, and now an unresolved suc-

cession process have cumulatively put pressure on that premium. The governance premium is an intangible asset — and intangible assets can erode long before balance sheets show the damage. The biggest concern now is that Tata appears not to have had a settled succession plan well before Chandrasekaran's term approached its end. When Mistry was removed in 2016, Tata Sons established a selection committee and appointed Chandrasekaran within a few months. His second term was approved in 2022. There has, therefore, been considerable time to think about the next phase. Yet six months after his reappointment was first considered, there was still no consensus. For an institution that prides itself on long-term thinking, this is difficult to explain. Succession planning should be a continuous board responsibility.

The Tata Sons Board now has three immediate responsibilities: First, find the right leader, not merely an available one. The next chairman must have the stature to command the confidence of the Trusts, the Tata Sons board, operating-company boards, employees and investors.

Second, make a new separation of ownership and management work. The 2022 Article 118 amendment provides the architecture. The board must now develop the institutional protocols



The Tata group has survived leadership transitions before. It will survive this one too. It needs to emerge from this transition stronger.

that make that architecture effective. Third, restore strategic clarity. Tata is simultaneously investing in semiconductors, electronics, and aviation while dealing with challenges at some established businesses. The next chairman will have to balance nation-building ambitions with capital discipline and shareholder returns.

The Tata group has survived leadership transitions before. It will survive this one too. But survival is not the objective. It needs to emerge from this transition stronger. Tata's stability has implications for investor confidence, corporate governance standards, and India's credibility as a global business ecosystem.

The Tatas do not need to return to the old model where ownership and management were embodied in the same individual. They need to build something better. An institutional model where ownership can exercise stewardship, management can exercise authority, and both can coexist without ambiguity.

The Tata name was built over 150 years on "leadership with spirit". The next chapter will test whether that trust can be institutionalised.

Lloyd Mathias is a business strategist and independent director. The views expressed are personal

A forced pause for India's solar power generation

One hates to admit this, but India may have to temporarily pause further addition to its renewable capacity, especially solar. There are two roadblocks that have led to a situation where it must back down on renewable generation. The first is that it is not able to provide long-term permanent grid connectivity, and the second, perhaps more important, is that we have practically no storage capacity, be it batteries or pumped storage.

Renewable generating capacity is more dispersed compared to conventional capacity, and, further, the capacities are relatively small. Consequently, one needs a transmission system that may run into a mesh of wires connecting small capacities instead of a single transmission line emanating from a big plant as we are used to. More lines would mean more "right of way" required to lay the cables. Apart from being a time-consuming affair, the fact is that the country does not have enough space available, at least in some parts. Moreover, the time required for setting up a solar plant is about 18 months whereas time taken for a transmission line can take about 36 months. This mismatch has led to a situation where the generation unit is ready but the transmission line is nowhere in sight. So, today, the generator waits compensation — that in itself is a lengthy legal battle.

During the solar hours, we have generation from not only solar but also wind, bio-gas, etc. to the extent they are connected to the grid. In addition, we have conventional generation from coal, gas, nuclear and hydro. The total generation from conventional and renewable sources is more than the demand for power during the day, at least as of now. So, somebody needs to back down since supply and demand need to match in real-time; otherwise, the grid will crash. The question is who should back down. Since the marginal cost of generation from solar and wind is zero, it is the conventional generation, such as coal, that needs to back down. In other words, renewable generation is treated as "must run" because unless you have that power, we are going to lose it forever.

But herein lies the catch. Coal-based generation cannot back down beyond a limit. The generators say, they would not be advisable to back down beyond 55% of the capacity of the plant because doing so may damage the machinery. The government, however, opines that there is no problem in backing down to even 40%. What should be this floor level (55% or 40%) is the matter of an ongoing debate.

IF INDIA DOESN'T WANT TO PAUSE ITS RENEWABLE GENERATION, ONE SOLUTION THAT HAS BEEN TALKED ABOUT IS TO TEMPORARILY MOTHBALL A FEW OF THE COUNTRY'S INEFFICIENT COAL-BASED PLANTS. BUT THAT DOESN'T SEEM POSSIBLE GIVEN DEMAND DURING NON-SOLAR HOURS

Now that India's solar capacity has touched 162 gigawatts (GW), the situation is such that even after going down to the floor level as far as generation from coal stations is concerned, supply is still exceeding demand. One, therefore, is now forced to curtail renewable generation also for grid stability. The curtailment was of the order of about 2 billion units (BU) in 2025. If India had storage capacity in the form of batteries, it could have used this surplus power to charge and use these batteries during non-solar hours.

The country could have used this surplus power to pump water from the lower reservoir to the upper reservoir of pumped hydro and use it when generation went down in the non-solar hours.

As already mentioned, solar generators are suffering due to non-availability of grid connectivity. They have been demanding compensation, and there is some talk of providing limited support. In addition, when solar generators are asked to back down, they are paid only to the extent they have supplied. However, a lot depends on the power purchase agreement that they have signed. In case there is a "deemed generation" clause, and if they are asked to back down for reasons other than grid stability, there is a possibility that they will be paid.

The process, however, can be lengthy. So, how does India get out of this morass? The answer lies in building storage capacity. The Central Electricity Authority (CEA) has estimated that the country needs storage capacity to the extent of 888 gigawatt-hours (GWH) by 2035; what it has today is a mere fraction of this. Storage capacity in the form of pumped storage takes time as it faces all the vagaries associated with the construction of hydro plants.

Though the gestation period for battery storage is relatively low, a new problem has emerged as far storage projects are concerned. The market-determined price (that has been arrived through competitive bidding) needs to be non-renewable, and this affects the viability of projects and puts a big question mark on their successful completion. If India wishes not to back down on its renewable generation, one possible solution seems to be temporarily mothballing a few of the country's inefficient coal-based plants so that overall generation from coal falls to an extent. In the meanwhile, the country focuses on seriously building its storage capacity. This, unfortunately, will not be possible since there are instances of high demand during non-solar hours where conventional generation falls short vis-à-vis demand.

To conclude, there seems to be no quick solution to India's problem of having to curtail renewable generation in the day and losing that power forever. On the lighter side, one can say that the country is better off adding only about 13 GW per year (as we have done over the last ten years) instead of about 45 GW per year that was required to displace coal. Had we done that, our problems would have multiplied and this crisis would have been at our doorsteps much earlier.

Somit Dasgupta is visiting professor, IITR, and former member (economic and commercial), Central Electricity Authority. The views expressed are personal

ESMAIL BAGHAEI | FOREIGN MINISTRY SPOKESPERSON, IRAN

Insecurity in the Strait of Hormuz was imposed on us ... and on the entire world, and the reason for it was the US

Ecological equity needs constitutional protection

Ecological inequality is now one of the most significant, yet least recognised, forms of inequality in India. Geographic variation may explain this asymmetry, but it cannot justify constitutional inequality, when unequal ecological burdens shape people's lives so differently, the issue becomes constitutional. Article 14 of the Constitution has two connotations: equality before law, which prohibits arbitrariness, and equal protection of laws, which requires differentiated support for unequal situations. Article 38(2) directs the State to reduce inequalities "among groups of people residing in different areas". Ecological inequality falls squarely within this mandate.

The Himalayas, Northeastern, and Western Ghats regions carry far higher ecological fragility, greater watershed responsibility, and a significantly heavier disaster mitigation burden than the plains. This mismatch between the constitutional principles and ecological reality has created a blind spot India can no longer afford.

Forest-rich states shoulder ecological responsibilities whose benefits flow to the entire nation. They preserve carbon sinks, stabilise monsoon systems, and maintain biodiversity. Industrialised states enjoy higher fiscal returns with lower ecological burdens. Applying identical rules to both produces outcomes that are not only inefficient but constitutionally infirm. This asymmetry also distorts equal opportunity under Article 16. Forest states cannot industrialise freely due to statutory protections, which limit jobs, infrastructure, and fiscal capacity.

Uniform national environmental policies create unequal forest distribution, pollution exposure, climate vulnerability and access to natural resources. When applied to states with radically different ecological burdens, these become a source of inequity. Indian jurisprudence has focused on forest diversion, compliance and legality, without addressing ecological inequality under Articles 14, 38(2) or 21. Recognising ecologically fragile states as a distinct class under Article 14, supported by Article 38(2), would enable asymmetric regulatory obligations, targeted fiscal transfers and region-specific forest strategies. India's forest policy recognises ecological asymmetry by prescribing 3% forest and tree cover nationally and 68% in hilly and mountainous regions; yet, budgetary allocations and governance frameworks treat plains and hill states as identical. This cannot achieve ecological equality unless the Centre supports states in proportion to their ecological burdens.

Judicial interventions have expanded Article 14 to prevent arbitrary environmental harm, but they have not recognised ecological inequality between states. Continuous mandamus in forest matters has centralised decision making with

out acknowledging differentiated ecological burdens. Ecological justice requires positive discrimination — fiscal transfers, differentiated regulatory burdens and asymmetric development pathways — which clashes with traditional rights of equality as non-discrimination. The Constitution does not prohibit asymmetry; it prohibits arbitrariness. Differentiated ecological support is thus an expression of equality.

The Forest Rights Act (FRA) and the Biological Diversity Act are held as guarantees of the rights of forest-dependent communities. FRA is built on a linear architecture: rights and titles are issued once, with no ecological feedback. But forests regenerate and shift through cyclical processes requiring baselines, monitoring and adaptive management. Without these, Gram Sabhas hold authority without stewardship capacity. The Northern states have faced a dual crisis: shrinking forest cover alongside persistently weak economic growth. Experiencing forest loss without corresponding economic opportunity creates precisely the regional inequality Article 38(2) seeks to minimise.

The Compensatory Afforestation Fund Act (CAMPA) offers a financial structure that fails to deliver ecological justice: 90% of the collections in a state go to that state's CAMPA fund, while 10% goes to the national fund. This national fund should support regions facing ecological deficits, irrespective of where the funds were collected. Yet the absence of uniform national fund — has prevented it from serving this purpose.

Justice-oriented forest governance model must recognise circularity — the ecological rule that every right over a forest must carry a responsibility to sustain its regeneration. Embedding this principle can harmonise rights, responsibilities and regeneration. And Payment for Ecosystem Services can reward communities for sustaining ecological functions. Article 21 gives this argument its deepest grounding. Unequal forest distribution translates directly into unequal environmental rights. Articles 14 and 21 converge to articulate a single mandate: Ecological equality is integral to the right to life.

A justice-oriented model must acknowledge that forest-rich states subsidise the nation's climate stability, forest-poore regions require sustained ecological investment and forest-dependent communities deserve protection. Articles 14, 38(2) and 21 offer a coherent constitutional blueprint for this.

Sudhanshu Gupta is a retired member of the Indian Forest Service and an international member of the Forest Stewardship Council. The views expressed are personal

HT
Top court again rebuffs Trump in \$5mn Carroll case
WASHINGTON: Rebuffing President Donald Trump for a second time, the US Supreme Court declined on Monday to hear his appeal of a \$5 million verdict in favour of E. Jean Carroll after a jury found him liable for sexually abusing and defaming the former magazine columnist. **REUTERS**

Pakistan detains 258 foreigners in scam centre raid
ISLAMABAD: Pakistan authorities said on Monday they detained 258 foreigners, including 40 Chinese nationals, following a raid on an alleged 'scam call centre' in the capital Islamabad. **AFP**

Thousands await aid after quake kills 68 in Indonesia
REO, INDONESIA: Thousands of people waited for aid on the Indonesian island of Flores on Monday as the country marked its 81st Independence Day, two days after a powerful earthquake killed at least 68 people, injured more than 200 others and damaged homes. **AP**

Nvidia set to back OpenAI project with \$105bn funding
OHIO: Nvidia Corp. has agreed to spend as much as \$105 billion to support a massive new data centre campus in Ohio set to be leased by OpenAI, marking the latest tie-up between two dominant forces driving the AI boom. OpenAI said it will only begin paying as capacity becomes available for lease. **BLOOMBERG**

Trump threatens to bomb Oman over Hormuz issue

President Donald Trump said that the US is not seeking an extension of 60-day MOU with Iran that ended on Monday

Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Monday that Iran should surrender to end a war with the US as talks between the countries remained stalled.

"They should put up the white flag of surrender," Trump told a Fox News reporter during a phone interview.

An interim deal agreed to in June declared an "immediate and permanent termination of military operations on all fronts," but quickly unraveled, with Trump saying it was "over" on July 7 and Iran's foreign ministry declaring it "suspended" a week later.

Under that memorandum of understanding (MOU), Iran and the US committed to negotiating a final deal — covering broader issues such as the fate of Iran's nuclear programme — in a maximum of 60 days, extendable by mutual consent. Monday marked 60 days since the MOU was signed.

Oman-Iran talks
Separately, Oman and Iran have been in talks to try to reach an agreement to restore commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, which carried 20% of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas supplies before the US-Israeli attacks on Iran began in late February.

"If Oman gets in the way, we'll bomb the s*** out of them," Trump told Fox.

The dispute over control of the Strait of Hormuz has driven up fuel prices and put pressure



Vessels transit through the Gulf of Oman off Muscat coast. **AFP**

Saudi-Turkey-Pak defence pact a 'big, bold' step, says Trump

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump has termed the Saudi Arabia-Turkey-Pakistan defence agreement a "big, bold and important first step" towards defending themselves in a "more meaningful way".

Trump's remarks on Sunday came days after the three nations signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement — holding any armed offensive against any of the three countries an attack against all of them.

"Very happy to see that Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Pakistan have recently, and finally, signed the Mecca

Joint Defence Agreement. It shows how the Middle East is coming together, and how countries will finally be able to defend themselves in a more meaningful way," Trump said in a post on Truth Social. "Congratulations to the Great Leadership of the three Nations mentioned. THIS IS A BIG, BOLD, AND IMPORTANT FIRST STEP — WOW."

The agreement was signed on August 7 by Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif. **PTI**

on Trump to end a war that is unpopular at home ahead of the November midterm elections that will decide control of the US Congress.

Trump told Fox News that the midterms were not impacting his strategy on Iran. "Midterms have nothing to do with

my thinking," he said.

Earlier on Monday, Trump posted on his Truth Social platform: "The number one goal is, and always will be, that Iran cannot have, in any way, shape, or form, a Nuclear Weapon," repeating one of his stated rationales for the war.

KUSHNER'S TALKS WITH ISRAEL, HAMAS END WITHOUT ANY PROGRESS

JERUSALEM: Donald Trump's envoy and son-in-law Jared Kushner on Monday wrapped up two days of meetings with Israeli and Hamas leaders to break a stalemate over the US president's Gaza plan, but there were no signs of an imminent breakthrough as both sides dug in.

Kushner met Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in Israel a day after meeting Hamas' political leader in Egypt in a bid to revive the plan, which has stalled as Israel has carried out airstrikes and seized more territory in Gaza despite an October ceasefire, while Hamas has refused to give up its weapons.

The Hamas group said it agreed to the roadmap but implementation depended on Israel first meeting its own commitments, including halting attacks and withdrawing. **REUTERS**

SHIPPING VIA HORMUZ SLOWS FOLLOWING ATTACKS ON TANKERS

SINGAPORE: Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz slowed over the weekend, data showed on Monday, following attacks on tankers, while US-Iran talks to resolve the Middle East conflict stalled. Five commodity vessels transited the strait on Saturday, with none registered for Sunday, shiptracking data from Kpler showed, versus 31 in the prior weekend.

Ships entering the strait on Saturday included an empty Very Large Crude Carrier with its Automatic Identification System switched off and an Indian-flagged Very Large Gas Carrier that used the Iranian route, Kpler data showed.

Shipping appeared to grind to a near standstill after the United Arab Emirates said three vessels operated by the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company were attacked in transit last week. **REUTERS**

UK PM exchanged messages with top Trump aide imposter

Bloomberg, AP & PTI
letters@hindustantimes.com

LONDON: UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham exchanged messages with somebody impersonating one of Donald Trump's closest advisers, according to people familiar with the matter.

Britain's new premier communicated with someone posing as White House Chief of Staff Susie Wiles, the people familiar said, speaking on condition of anonymity.

"We do not comment on national security matters," 10 Downing Street said in a statement. The communications were first reported by Politico on Monday morning.

Politico cited four unnamed officials in first reporting that Burnham thought he was messaging with Susie Wiles before he became suspicious and cut off communications.

Burnham, who took charge at



Andy Burnham, Susie Wiles

10 Downing Street on July 20, is said to have engaged with the spurious messages in the days before and after assuming his new role.

Politico quoted a person briefed on the communications that a "few messages" were exchanged but insisted they were "of no significance" and were "quickly" reported to the appropriate authorities once their suspicious nature became clear.

The communication between Burnham and the person posing as Wiles is believed to have been only in the form of messages,

with no conversation having taken place. The British embassy in Washington was concerned enough about the incident that it raised the matter with the White House, Politico reported officials, who preferred to remain anonymous, as saying.

The White House said the incident had nothing to do with Wiles' devices being hacked.

Last year, the White House and the Federal Bureau of Investigation launched an investigation after US senators, governors and business executives received texts and phone calls from someone claiming to be Trump's chief of staff.

The Wall Street Journal reported at the time that Wiles told associates that her cellphone contacts had been hacked.

"Nobody can impersonate Susie. There's only one Susie," Trump said at the time.

Black academic death: Cambridge head slams 'racist feeding frenzy'

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

LONDON: The head of Cambridge university on Monday condemned a "racist feeding frenzy" prompted by plagiarism claims against black academic Jason Arday, as his supporters prepared for a London vigil after his death last week.

Arday, who became Cambridge's youngest ever black professor in 2023, was found dead on Friday aged 41, following multiple plagiarism accusations.

Chris Smith, the University of Cambridge's chancellor, told the BBC he believed it was "important for such claims to be 'rigorously investigated'".

But he added it was right to "refuse to join in a racist feeding



Jason Arday **AP**

frenzy over a particular academic", without naming Arday directly.

Arday, the professor of sociology of education at the prestigious university in eastern England, resigned August 5 after accusations he had plagiarised parts of his doctoral thesis and exaggerated personal achievements prompted a media storm.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



MICROSOFT, RIVALS
EYE BUYOUT OF HR
FIRM DARWINBOX

Sneha Shah

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MUMBAI: KKR-backed services provider Darwinbox is drawing buyout interest even as it prepares for a potential public listing over the next couple of years. Existing investors Salesforce and Microsoft, along with US-based HR and payroll services provider ADP, have approached its founders and board with the intention to buy them out, three people with knowledge of the development said. Darwinbox was valued at around \$1 billion when it raised \$440 million from KKR and Partners Group in March last year.

"All the options are on the table. That is the beauty of the current capital markets in India," one of the persons cited above said on the condition of anonymity, as these discussions are private.

According to this person, from time to time, investors Salesforce and Microsoft have been expressing their desire to acquire the company. High growth SaaS (software as a service) companies with domain expertise are seeing a lot of traction from global financial as well as strategic investors, and Darwinbox is no different," the person said. The firm has so far raised \$250 million across various funding rounds. Other investors include 3one4 Capital, Lightspeed, Sequoia, Salesforce, Microsoft and TCV.

A spokesperson for Darwinbox denied any talks for a stake sale, saying the company plans to pursue an initial public offering (IPO) in the medium term and is on track to do so. Queries emailed to Microsoft and Salesforce remained unanswered. An ADP spokesperson declined to comment.

According to the second person in the know, while Salesforce and Microsoft want to add payroll services to their bouquet of products, companies such as ADP that are already into the domain want to deepen their expertise. "Darwinbox sits right in the middle of the aspirations of these companies," said this person, adding that the company's board is yet to take a call on the offer to get it getting. The third person said Darwinbox is now likely to be valued at around \$1.2-2.0 billion.

Small firms could get big relief on bank guarantees

Performance bank guarantee may go as govt plans to leverage existing schemes

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NEW DELHI: The Centre aims to ease cash concerns for smaller enterprises by scrapping stiff performance bank guarantees required for government contracts, two officials aware of the discussions said. Instead, the government plans to marshal existing schemes to support the performance requirement, potentially freeing up working capital totalling trillions of rupees for enterprises that form the backbone of the Indian industry.

The Union ministry for micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSME) is discussing the proposal with the department for promotion of industry and internal trade (DPIIT), the two government officials cited earlier said on condition of anonymity. Many government contracts mandate MSMEs to furnish a performance bank guarantee to compensate the government for potential defaults, burdening small businesses living on thin margins.



The proposal is expected to bring relief to India's over 74 million MSMEs, which account for over 30% of GDP.

According to the first government official cited above, India's General Financial Rules of 2017 require a performance bank guarantee. "There, our thinking is to bring convergence—there are many credit guarantee schemes run by the government, many of them for MSMEs specifically. So, instead of nudging MSMEs to set up performance bank guarantees, why not link it with the Centre's credit guarantee schemes and take that option," the official said.

The proposal is expected to bring relief to India's over 74 million MSMEs, which account for over 30% of GDP, 35.4% of manufacturing output, nearly

45% of exports, and employ over 320 million people. Industry stakeholders said the relief would be welcome, particularly as it has been a long-standing demand of the MSME sector, where the vast majority of enterprises are micro units with a turnover of less than ₹10 crore.

"Removal of performance bank guarantees in government-MSME contracts has been a long-standing plea by the industry, as it forces the smallest businesses to put a significant part of its working capital aside, making any room for business expansion even narrower," said Vinod Kumar, president of the India

SME Forum, an MSME lobby group representing about 100,000 businesses.

The development assumes significance as MSMEs accounted for 50% of the central government's ₹2.30 trillion procurement of goods and services in FY26. According to the General Financial Rules, 2017, MSMEs that secure a government contract valued at over ₹10 lakh must furnish a performance bank guarantee worth 3-10% of the project value.

A report by private research firm A.T. Kearney in November 2025 estimated that nearly 4.5% of India's GDP, or about ₹15 trillion, remains frozen in bank guarantees.

According to the plan, the government is considering using these credit guarantees, under which businesses account collateral-free bank loans and the Centre promises to cover lenders' losses in case of default, in place of performance bank guarantees. This will require banks to "de-risk" their lending by providing collateral or other forms of security.

Experts say that replacing performance bank guarantees with government credit guarantees could reduce the financial burden on MSMEs and free up working capital.

SC to hear NBCC's RERA plea in Supertech case

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine the plea filed by government's construction arm NBCC India Limited seeking exemptions under the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act (RERA) for completion of the insolvent-supertech Supertech projects.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant issued notice on NBCC's plea challenging the May '22 order of the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) refusing to grant such an exemption. The NCLAT also turned down the plea for enhanced fees on sale of the unfinished flats in 16 Supertech projects taken over by NBCC in December 2024.

Attorney general R Venkataraman, appearing for NBCC, told the court that the imposition of full RERA compliance will expose NBCC to "delay compensation, penalties and consent-based impediments" as he urged the court to consider passing an order similar to the one issued by the NCLAT.

The bench, also comprising justices Jayaprakash Narayan and V Mohana, agreed to consider NBCC's plea and issued notice to the Union Bank of India (which initiated corporate insolvency resolution process against Supertech), the interim resolution professional of Supertech, and suspended Supertech director Ram Kishore Arora.

On the other issue of denying fees, the NBCC claimed a separate 1% marketing fee over and above the \$8.5 project management consultant (PMC) fee which it had claimed as the 16 projects. However, it was aggrieved by the NCLAT order



In February, the top court had approved the takeover of 16 Supertech projects by NBCC.

restructuring the fee-matrix as a consolidated 8% (7% PMC + 1% marketing), which, according to NBCC, undermined project viability and disincentivised the implementing agency.

The plea filed before the top court said that unlike any promoter, NBCC has a limited role as executing agency and the order of NCLAT has the effect of "undermining the commercial and legal viability" of the mandate of NBCC.

It further stated that if the NCLAT order is not interfered with, the smooth execution of the Supertech completion plan will be imperilled and a "disincentivising signal" will go to public sector entities who may be willing to step in as implementing agencies in future distressed real-estate cases.

In February 2026, the top court had approved the takeover of 16 Supertech projects by NBCC and in a separate proceedings, the court had formed an Apex Court Committee (ACC) to explore whether all 30 Supertech projects situated across the country should be taken over by NBCC. This issue is still under consideration of the NCLAT.

The 16 Supertech projects are located in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Bengaluru.

CENTRE TO FORM PANEL TO REVIEW BANKING SECTOR

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NEW DELHI: After strengthening India's banks, the government is preparing to constitute a high-powered committee to comprehensively review the sector and align it with India's next phase of growth. Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Monday. Speaking on the seven themes during a conference of state-owned banks, Public Sector Bank (PSB) Conference 2026, in New Delhi, the minister said the two days of "intensive" discussions are happening at a time when "the announcement on the high-powered committee to look into banking for Viksit Bharat" is expected.

The seven thematic tracks of the two-day conference are—deposit mobilisation, banking for youth, supporting the investment cycle, supporting global capability centres (GCCs), agriculture and horticulture value chain infrastructure, re-imagining the credit card business and the priority sector lending.

Addressing the bankers at the conference, Sitharaman said: "Soon, the committee will be announced and the material that you are producing from [the] two-day discussions on the basis of well-researched set of documents—which have been shared with you in advance—will helpfully provide the substantive material for the committee to also look at."

In her budget speech on February 15, Sitharaman said India's banking sector is now characterised by strong balance sheets, historic highs in profitability, improved asset quality and coverage exceeding 98% of villages in the country. "At this juncture, we are well placed to futuristically evaluate the measures needed to continue on the path of reform-led growth of this sector," she said. In that speech she proposed setting up a "High Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat" to comprehensively review the sector and align it with India's next phase of growth, while safeguarding financial stability, inclusion and consumer protection.

Unemployment rate falls to 5.1% in July

Abhishek Jha

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NEW DELHI: India's headline unemployment rate came in at 5.1% in July, marginally lower than the 5.2% figure in July last year, although unemployment of people in the 15-29 years age group increased by 0.70 percentage points, a number that is bound to cause concern, especially in the wake of Gen Z protests across India last month.

The fact that unemployment in the segment increased despite no change in their labour force participation rate is even more concerning.

The numbers are from Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) data released by the National Statistics Office (NSO) on Monday. The headline number is in keeping with the marginal decline seen in unemployment rate in May and June.

To be sure, the trend in unem-

ployment was opposite for men and women: rural and urban areas; and the young and old. Unemployment rate increased by 10 basis points—one basis point is one hundredth of a percentage point—compared to last year in rural areas to 4.5%. In urban areas, the rate decreased by 50 basis points to 6.2%.

Similarly, a gender-wise disaggregation shows that female unemployment increased 30 basis points to 5.4% while male

unemployment decreased by 30 basis points to 5%. Youth unemployment rate fell by 10 basis points for the 15-29 age group—also increased by 70 basis points to 15.6%. To be sure, sequentially, unemployment rate fell for even the young and women. However, labour market indicators are usually compared for the same month across years to account for seasonality of jobs, such as those in agriculture.

RAZORPAY BUILDS AI MODEL TO IMPROVE PAYMENT SUCCESS RATES

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NEW DELHI: Even as India's digital payments infrastructure handles close to 23 billion UPI transactions and around 590 million credit card payments every month, Razorpay believes artificial intelligence (AI) can plug persistent gaps. In partnership with Nvidia and Amazon Web Services (AWS), the payments company has developed Razorpay Vulcan, India's first AI-based payment foundation model.

"In the early data testing with more than 1.5 million transactions across more than 50,000 merchants and businesses, we have seen an 8 to 10% improvement in payment success rates, and a 5x reduction in fraud with those transactions blocked," Harshil Mathur, CEO & Founder of Razorpay, tells HT.

For Vulcan, Razorpay utilises Nvidia's silicon clusters, mostly top-end H100 GPUs. AWS provided scalable cloud infrastructure and architectural guidance to handle enterprise transaction volumes reliably.

Why develop a model from scratch? Mathur points out that open-source choices were limited to large language models (LLMs). While they excel at conversational tasks, they cannot model payment behaviour. "There was no pre-existing foundational model for Indian payments that we could fine-tune," he says.

Razorpay avoided third-party models to ensure privacy, complying with RBI data localisation norms and the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act.

All personally identifiable information is removed from transactions before reaching Vulcan, which is hosted and executed entirely within Razorpay's private infrastructure in India. Building a proprietary model was crucial because payments data behaves fundamentally differently from natural language, with no public datasets at this scale.

Trained on 3 trillion metrics from 4 billion payments, Vulcan's self-learning Transformer architecture understands "the language of the movement of money," automatically capturing shifting payment patterns.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Every Saturday, HT Brunch explores the people, ideas and cultural shifts behind the moments everyone is talking about.

RELAX. THE WEEKEND'S HERE
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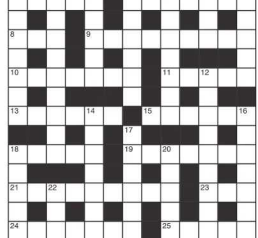
{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

- ACROSS**
- 1 Make use of one in the union (5)
 - 2 Uncle Arthur's day off? It isn't apparent (7)
 - 3 Consume stirred tea (6)
 - 4 Safe could be unsatisfying (9)
 - 5 Nature's new source of refreshment (3,4)
 - 6 Sorts of riddles? (5)
 - 7 In bad way (6)
 - 8 Napping, the general is swallowed by a snake (9)
 - 9 A way to cook a variety of meats (5)
 - 10 He doesn't believe he needs endless capital (7)
 - 11 Very well, do better friend! (9)
 - 12 She's a little intimidated (3)
 - 13 Big steps tried out on board? (7)
 - 14 Teams that can't be taken objectively (5)
- DOWN**
- 1 The weather is changing so wrap up (7)
 - 2 Return to the country, the scene of the crime (9)
 - 3 Stage make-up (5)
 - 4 Being restless is not any use but might be (6)
 - 5 They make up a meal from different sources (7)
 - 6 First person Gregory takes to heart (3)
 - 7 Files a letter as an afterthought (5)
 - 8 At which can invigorate the long-distance runner (5,4)
 - 9 Kind of company restricted in scope (7)
 - 10 A man who has not been seen for a long time (9)
 - 11 They give work to doctors, sorrows to the church (6)
 - 12 Blows on the feet (5)
 - 13 Heat of sudden going round by a deep gorge (5)
 - 14 One stroke put up a good score (3)

PUZZLE 17567

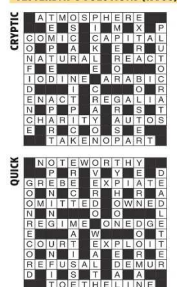
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QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
- 1 Drink made from apples (5)
 - 2 Letter of French romantic school (6)
 - 3 Oppose by legal argument (5)
 - 4 Madonna (6)
 - 5 To the extent that (2,3,2)
 - 6 Removable cover (3)
 - 7 Pleasing in favour of (6)
 - 8 Person, subject of experience (5,3)
 - 9 Place of concealment (7)
 - 10 Obtain with difficulty (7)
 - 11 Inflammable petroleum jelly (6)
 - 12 Concentrate attention (5)
 - 13 Cry of sheep or goat (5)
 - 14 Silent (3)
- DOWN**
- 1 Begin correspondence with (7)
 - 2 Letter of French romantic school (6)
 - 3 Oppose by legal argument (5)
 - 4 Madonna (6)
 - 5 To the extent that (2,3,2)
 - 6 Removable cover (3)
 - 7 Pleasing in favour of (6)
 - 8 Person, subject of experience (5,3)
 - 9 Place of concealment (7)
 - 10 Obtain with difficulty (7)
 - 11 Inflammable petroleum jelly (6)
 - 12 Concentrate attention (5)
 - 13 Cry of sheep or goat (5)
 - 14 Silent (3)

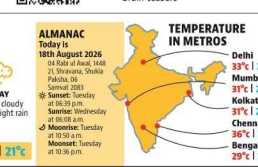
YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17566)



{ SUDOKU } DIFFICULTY LEVEL: ★★★★★

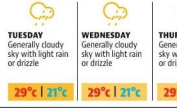


Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE - HIGH - LOW



ALMANAC

Today is 18th August 2026
24th of the month, 14th of the year, 2026
Sunset: 5:31 PM
Moonset: 5:31 PM
Moonrise: 5:31 PM

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 39°C / 24°C
Mumbai 37°C / 26°C
Kolkata 31°C / 27°C
Chennai 38°C / 27°C
Bengaluru 29°C / 21°C

